# Understanding (Repkyle)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30116421.

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Teen And Up Audiences

**Archive Warning:**
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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M/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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**Additional Tags:**
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# Understanding (Repkyle)

by moonrose8456

Summary

Kyle and Rogelio have been living peacefully in the waste since after the war. They've found love and safety in The Valley of the lost, and all is well, until a stranger with links to the past shows up and threatens to tear it all apart.

At first they feel unsure, how bad could it be? But Kyle is more important than he was previously led to believe.

# one

Rogelio's POV

Kyle always tells me stories about his day, about what's going on in the world, what havoc Imp has been wreaking across the Crimson Waste. He tells me how much he loves me.

I can't respond the way he can.

I listen to his voice, the voice that calms me down after a panic attack, the voice that grounds me when I feel as though I could kill somebody with anger, and then he waits for me to speak. It warms my heart, how although I can't speak with words, he'll place a hand on the side of my face and give me that smile that tells me to open up.

And so I'll tell him how I'm feeling with a look, or I'll show him how much I care about him with a kiss, or I'll place my hand over his to make sure he stays. But the times that seem to really warm my heart are the times when I try to speak to him, and he tries to understand.

He's been learning how to understand my way of communicating from Lonnie, and I appreciate it in ways that I can't even begin to describe, but there's something special about telling him a story and seeing him smile even if it was terrible in reality, or watching him blush when I tell him I love him because it's the only phrase he can understand. For now, it's wordless whispers, small grunts that he's free to decipher in whatever ways he wants to.

I guess that's why as I lay with him in front of me, curled around his body with his back pressing against my stomach and hugging him with my tail, I'm reminded of the fact that he loves me, and I love him too. For once, nothing can take this away from us.

He nuzzles into me and the tough skin on my chest tingles where his soft hair brushes against it. He smells like fresh fruit. His hand

reaches up slowly like he knows I'm awake, and he both gently and blindly runs his hand down my cheek and along my jawline. I can feel my stomach squirming.

This always happens. He touches me, or looks at me, and my entire nervous system seems to collapse. That's quite admirable, given that he's an anxious wreck who cries when I 'look at him funny' and I'm not usually so open to emotions that make me feel vulnerable.

"Hey, Ro."
He yawns, turning his head slightly to see my face. I smile at him and open my mouth, but hesitate. I don't want to ruin the moment. We're both wearing sweatpants, but our bare abdomens brush together as we breathe.

Kyle rolls over completely so that we're face to face, his finger tracing circles on my arm as I hug him tighter with my tail.

"It's so early."
He says. His smile is so sweet, so genuine, that it makes my heart ache every time. He looks behind me and out through the tiny gap in our 'curtains' that's really just one of my t-shirts hung on the window frame. We don't exactly have the luxury of living in a castle like others do.

If I was to guess, I would say it's around six.

The sky is an orange colour and white streaky clouds can be seen above the horizon. Or room is still cast under a shadow, considering theres no room for light to get in through the curtain. Not much places get light in the Crimson Waste.

I shrug and bow my head so that our foreheads touch, and even in the dark I see his cheeks flush pink. He kisses me suddenly and I pull him closer, feeling like maybe I won't ruin the moment by trying to say something-

"Kyle? Rogelio?"
Someone says from the foot of our bed. We both jump and Kyle

yelps in terror, scrambling away from me and pulling the covers up to his nose. I don't even realise I'm pointing the staff I keep beside me when I sleep at the source of the voice until they look at me funny.

At the foot of our bed stands two familiar silhouettes. Kyle turns on the lamp and I groan at the sudden light, but I'm cut short when one of the intruders, or more fitting, interrupters, let's out a huge sigh.

"Woah, I'm so relieved! Glimmer was all 'Let's teleport to their room!' and I was like 'That's definitely not a good idea!' And she was like, it's not like they'll be doing anything-"
Kyle flushes crimson and I can't help but relate to him. I mean, we're half naked right now.

"Adora? Glimmer? Why are you here?!"
He asks in a hushed tone, giving me a nervous side-glance. We both know they wouldn't come to us unannounced if it wasn't important, let alone at this hour of the morning. Glimmer frowns.

"We're having a meeting back at the castle, we can explain everything. We just need you guys to be there to consider."
She says. I look to Kyle and we both shrug at the same time. I nod to him and he smiles at me, before turning to the pair at the end of our bed. I can't help but feel really nervous right now.

"It's not ideal, but this was one of the few times we could get everyone together in one place."
Adora says.

"Uh, okay."
I clamber out of bed with no problem, but Kyle stays put, his cheeks turning red once more. I throw him our t-shirt curtain and he pulls it on hastily. I make do with a hoodie. Glimmer smiles at us and Kyle awkwardly does the same back, but I don't. It's either the morning grumpiness showing, or the fact that they intercepted something that was definitely going somewhere.
Adora gulps.

That is not a good sign.

When we take hold of Glimmer's arm we're zipped through both time and space to reappear inside the castle, outside a large door to a room we've certainly never seen before. Adora smiles nervously and Glimmer pushes the door open.

Kyle takes my hand in an instant and we both tense up at the sight before us. Catra, Bow, Sea-Hawk, Netossa, Spinnerella and all of the princesses smile at us from a large round table, all of them seated in tall and uncomfortable looking chairs. Not really what I was expecting. Kyle smiles at everyone in that unique and awkward way of his and I nod in all of their directions.

Glimmer takes her seat at her throne and Adora ushers us over to two stools that have been pushed over for us to sit on. When we sit down, everybody turns to the queen.

"I'm so confused."
Kyle whispers into my ear, so quietly I can barely hear him. I nod in agreement and we look at Glimmer. Our grip on each other's hands doesn't even threaten to loosen.

"Okay! Well, thank you to everyone for being here. I know that the princesses were here for a sleepover anyways, but the rest of you came, so thanks!"
Glimmer says with a cheery tone. How can she be this peppy this early in the morning? There's another thing I love about Kyle; he's quiet. Although something does seem off about Glimmer, like she's acting overly happy to mask another feeling inside.

"Something really weird happened and I think we should all address it. Catra? You can take over."
We all turn to Catra, who's sporting one of Adora's cropped t-shirts just like Kyle is wearing an oversized one of mine. Her hair is tucked into messy bun and her eyes are heavy and tired, but she smiles at everybody sitting at the table. So much for being a morning grouch like back at the Fright Zone... I guess we switched roles.

"Last night, me and Adora went for a walk. Everything was fine; the breeze was soft, the air was humid. But then..."
She reaches into her pocket and pulls out some kind of Crystal.

"Something flew over the planet. It looked like a ship, but I'm not even sure if it was one. I only saw this fly off of it, so I made Glimmer teleport us over to have a look."
Everybody looks at the crystal and then to each other. My stomach knots a little. Why does this have anything to do with us?

Kyle must be thinking the same thing, because he clears his throat and turns red once everybody looks at him. I squeeze his hand as a form of encouragement.

"Sorry to be uh... rude, but..."
I draw circles on the back of his hand with my thumb to call him down, just like I used to do when we were kids.

"Why were we called to this meeting? I mean... we know we weren't your first choice."
He gulps while Glimmer sighs and runs a hand through her poofy hair.

"We asked Lonnie, but she said she didn't want to fight anymore because she wants to take care of Imp. She told me to ask you two."
Fight? I feel myself beginning to sweat and I grunt in confusion. Kyle pats my back softly, but of course Catra is the only one who fully understands me. She and Lonnie had a knack for learning things about my strange dialect during our time with the Horde, and to be honest I think the only reason behind helping me out was because they treated it like a competition.

"We're not sure if we have to fight yet. We just thought you two would come in useful if it came down to it."
She responds. Kyle shakes his head.

"Why would finding a crystal thing come down to fighting?"
He asks. I nod. Everybody looks around the table and Adora

clears her throat, holding Catra's hand for support.

I'm not liking the looks of this.

"We're gonna need you guys to keep a good eye on the Waste." She says. Me and Kyle share a look.

"There's a message on the crystal, in first one's writing."
My eyes widen a little and Kyle's do to. He grips my hand a little tighter in anxiousness.

"It says to be careful, because they're coming. That's why I need all of you to keep guard of your kingdoms and tell us if anything strange happens. We don't know if they dropped it intentionally."
Everybody shares looks of worry and uncertainty. I can see that Kyle is having a bit of a panic attack, so I plant a gentle kiss on his forehead to help him relax. We've been trying to forget about all the times we fought against the rebellion, since it brings back unpleasant memories for the two of us. This isn't exactly helping.

"Who's coming?"
Bow asks, his arm slung around Glimmer's shoulders. Adora sighs and Catra nods for her to continue.

"The first ones."

# Two

Chapter Notes

Enjoy!

Kyle’s POV

"The war ended nearly three years ago. Why do we still have to fight?"
I say, anger lacing my tone. Ro shrugs and sits down on our sad excuse for a couch.

"I don't see why we have to help, either."
I sit down next to my boyfriend and hold my face in my hands, my elbows digging into my knees as I let out shaky breaths.

I've gone two months without a flashback. No memories of the Horde, of being bullied, of fighting innocent people... But now it's all flooding back, like the word 'fight' is a key that unlocks my anxiety. I feel a sturdy hand on my back and I try to relax, but it's useless.

A knock on our door sounds and Ro gets up to answer it, but I stay in my current position.

"Good, you're back. I'm guessing they told you about the crystal?"
Lonnie says, stumbling in the door with a familiar blue creature in her hands. Her voice rings in my head.

'the Crystal'

I sit up and turn to her, my eyebrows creased into a frown.

"Why didn't you tell us about it? Maybe I could've had a panic attack a bit earlier."
I ask. I notice that my tone is harsh, a little mean, even, but once I start to panic manners don't matter to me. Lonnie sighs and shoves Imp into Rogelio's arms before folding her own.

"I was busy. And besides, it's not like anything's actually going to happen around here."
She says. Rogelio shoots me a concerned look, but I shrug him off. I turn back and face away from them again. Of course she wouldn't tell us. After all these years she still leaves me out of everything.

I hear Rogelio's familiar growling and Lonnie scoffs. The only word I caught him say was 'alone'. Maybe he's telling her off.

"You guys gotta keep your hands off each other. You're getting all soft!"
Lonnie exclaims. Imp repeats her words and I squeeze my eyes shut.

'Soft'.

Why is that an insult? Why do I feel so offended when people tell me I'm soft? So what if I am?

"And?"
I ask. Rogelio sits next to me and shakes his head, Imp imitating him while perched on his knee.

He grumbles something and I completely understand him. I must be getting better 'She didn't say we were weak.'

I nod. He's right, as usual. She never called me weak, I just interpreted it that way.

"Whatever, Lonnie."
I grumble. She sits next to me and rests her legs up on our wobbly table.

"What have you two been up to, anyways? You barely come visit."
Rogelio and I share a guilty look and my cheeks burn up a little.

"We've been busy, I guess."
Lonnie frowns.

"I'd appreciate the stop by every now and then. Imp isn't exactly good company."
We nod. For a moment the silence hangs in the air, heavy and full of force. My mind wanders to the past before I can stop it. The past, when all three of us were so close that we were rarely seen apart. When Adora and Catra were still cadets, and they would play pranks on me. It was hard some days, but if I was going to be a distraction from their troubles I was willing.

Lonnie gets up and scoops her tiny blue friend up from Rogelio's arms.

"I get that you guys want to forget the past, and all the bad things we did. But that was our childhood."
And without missing a beat, she leaves. Paint crumbles to the floor when she shuts the door and I feel slightly nauseous, maybe from guilt. I think she's a bit mad.

"We're not bad for wanting to forget the past, are we?"
I ask. Ro shrugs and puts a pot of water over the stove. I've spent the last three years feeling guilty, and now I'm about to feel even worse about it? It's as though every time I try to relax a million voices start taking in my head, telling me how wrong I am, how I'm a bad person.

I turn and look at Rogelio. Maybe he's just heating up water, but there's something off about how he's acting. Not trying to cheer me up, (not that he's obligated to, but it's usually what he does), agreeing with everything I say?

"Uh, Ro? Is something wrong?"
Maybe I don't want to know. Even if I knew what the problem was I'm too awkward to help. He pours some of the hot water into two ceramic cups and drops a spoonful of cocoa powder into each before sitting next to me. Whenever we have hot chocolate it's never as nice as the ones from Bright Moon, made with creamy milk, but there's something familiar and homely about them.

I take the cup from his hands and sigh.

"You can talk to me, you know. I can only learn how to understand you better if you open up."
Rogelio looks at me for a minute, his eyes observing and skimming over every inch of my face, but doesn't linger as much as I wish he would.

"I'm getting better, Ro. I know what you're saying way more now than I could have before."
I say. My voice cracks a little and a bubble of worry rises up my throat. Why won't he talk-

My thoughts are interrupted when he finally speaks to me. His eyes are trained on the ground, but mine are focused on him and him only. I catch a few words.

'Accept','forget','who we are'.

"You want to accept... who we are?"
I ask. He smiles a little and shakes his head, my mistakes and lack of understanding has always been amusing to him. He says something else and I hear most of it.

"We can't forget? We can't forget who we are?"
He laughs and I know I'm wrong again. Although I'm frustrated I can't help but feel a smile creeping up on me. We both take a sip of our hot chocolate at the same time, and we give each other the same side-glance that we did when I first told him I loved him.

That look of shock, and happiness, all mixed into one. Like all of a sudden you realise that this is who you're destined to be with, and this is who you've been searching for all along.

"You want to... accept who we are?"
I try. He nods and grumbles out something else.

"We can't forget... we should accept..."
I tap my fingers on the cup in my hands and try to think, and then it hits me.

"We shouldn't forget the past, we should accept it as part of who we are!"
Rogelio nods and we both laugh.

Maybe it's the heat of the Valley of the Lost, or maybe it's the heat of the hot cup in my hands, but for what could be the fifth time today my face feels hot and itchy all of a sudden, and I just know that my cheeks are red. Ro places a hand on my left cheek and makes it worse, so I shove him away playfully.

"Hey, stop!"
I giggle when he starts to tickle me. I hastily put my cup on the table and try to get him back, but it's useless. We both laugh when I climb on top of him and try to tickle him, but instead I'm the one who gets it.

"Good luck now!"
I say, now straddling his legs and pinning his arms down. It doesn't take long for me to go red again. He raises his eyebrows and smiles at this and I have to force myself to look away before I get so embarrassed I shrivel up and die on the spot. I let go of him and lie down, my head resting on his chest and listening to his heartbeat.

It's fast, but slowing down. Like a train grinding to a halt, or breathing becoming more steady after running for a while. He runs his hand through my messy hair and my skin tingles where he touches me, sending shivers down my spine and around my whole body.

"I love you."

I whisper. Ro moves his hand to my back and growls something in return.

'I love you, too.'

# Three

Rogelio's POV

I wake up on the couch with a blanket draped over me. The room is dark, so I must have slept for a while. The note on the table beside my cold cup of hot chocolate is the only thing I can see clearly, so I open it up.

'Gone to get us some food!
Love, Kyle'

Hopefully he left earlier... even after the war the waste is unsafe after dark. He doesn't normally leave alone during the night unless he's trying to distract himself from something.

I get up slowly and trudge over to the window, peering out to the street outside. There's a couple of kids running around together, dodging their parents as they kick a football around. Eventually they go inside.

I watch as people begin to hang up curtains and wedge their doors shut, lighting candles that cast a soft glow out onto the path, their light dancing over the concrete walls and in through the window.

Deciding it's best to do the same, I take up a random towel from the chest of drawers in the corner of the room and tuck it into the window frame. When I turn on the lamp, our tiny flat is transformed into a warm home.

"Hi sleepy head."
Kyle says, slipping inside and shutting the door, sending flakes of paint to the ground just like very other time.

Our place is old and shabby. It was the only flat available in the area and we knew we couldn't spend any longer alone with Lonnie, so we took the first offer we could get. We could be living

in worse conditions, though. And as corny as it sounds, as long as I have Kyle I don't mind where we stay. Yeah, forget I said that.

Kyle kicks the wooden wedge that was on the table under the door so that it can't be opened, and I take the bag of food from him. His eyes look tired and worn, but his smile looks happy and full of life.

"You know, I like it here. It's not as bad as you make it out to be." He says, glancing at me. I pretend that I don't know what he's talking about, even though he obviously saw the way I was looking around.

'It's not the best.'
I say.

"If you said what I think you did, it doesn't have to be the best. Anywhere is better than the Fright Zone, okay?"
I roll my eyes and force myself to nod. I promised Kyle a year or two ago that we would get out of here one day, that I would find the perfect house for us to live in with zero distractions around and zero dangers nearby. Unfortunately, we haven't been able to do it just yet.

I usher for him to sit down and I sort the boiled vegetables from the bag he brought home out onto two plates. When I sit down, he nudges me with his elbow. How eyes still look tired.

"Thanks. You know... I was thinking on the way back,"
I nod for him to continue.

"The whole crystal thing? Even if something bad does happen... I think we'll be ok. We've already been through the worst, right?"
I swallow a mouthful of baby carrots and smile at him. Something's off.

'We'll be okay.'
I think he gets me. He turns to me and sets his plate down on the table so that all of his attention is on me. I do the same.

"Can I tell you something? It's kind of messed up..."
I nod. My Kyle? Messed up? He takes a deep breath and I notice his hands are trembling so I take them into mine.

"I'm scared. I know it was just one crystal with one message, and it might even be some kind of misunderstanding, but..."
His eyes well up with tears and he tries to blink them back, creating a glossy sheen across his pupils. I hold his hands a little tighter.

"I keep getting flashbacks. It's that thing- I'm so scared, Ro!"
I can see the panic in his eyes and my heart crumbles inside of me. I wrap my arms around him and move my hands up and down to try and relax him, but only more choked sobs follow.

Maybe the war between the rebellion and the horde ended years ago, but the war going on inside of Kyle's head between his happiness and trauma is still raging on. His hands ball into fists and those fists clutch onto my shirt, making me feel helpless.

'It's okay to be scared. You're strong. I'll protect you.'
Maybe he heard a load of growls, maybe he heard me word for word, or maybe he isn't even listening, but he nods anyways.

"I'm sorry, it's dumb. I think I'm gonna go to bed. You can have my dinner."
He says through his tears. I frown and ruffle up his hair, running my fingers through his blonde locks.

Nobody should have to feel this way. Nobody at all yet the lack of caring from the universe has destined Kyle for this pain. What did he do to deserve it?

He sits up again and let's out a shaky breath while I wipe the tears from his face.

"I feel bad for wasting our money like that... I mean I just went out and got it and now I'm having a mental freaking breakdown."
I can't help but smile at his cluelessness. It's just like him to push

his pain inside for the benefit of others, but I won't let it happen. Not this time.

'Go to sleep. We can eat all of this tomorrow.'
I say. He nods and makes his way into our bedroom, not bothering to change before I hear him slipping under the covers.

Kyle's POV

I feel numb.

Everywhere I look just becomes this giant mess of memories from my past, of fighting and losing people who meant something to me.

Even the sound Rogelio bagging up our wasted vegetables that probably won't be eaten tomorrow is finding a way to manifest into the sound of weapons and machinery, and his footsteps to the sound of us training to fight princesses.

I try to focus on the sound of him washing our plates, the soft rush of water from the faucet gentle but still present enough to distract me. Then I focus on my happiest memory. The one that I can always count on to drag me out of whatever this is and into a happier state.

~

The night was cold and harsh, wind was whipping against our faces and the rain was lashing down on top of our heads. Me and Rogelio were positioned inside of a cave, prepared to attack. We were sitting opposite each other.

Rogelio shouted somethingbover at me over the howling wind, and at the time I had no idea what he was saying. I just nodded and pretended to understand.

"Yeah, sure."
I could tell from the look I got back I gave the wrong response.

That was when the rougher winds came, and my fingertips started to go numb with the cold.

It was Rogelio who helped me feel warm.

He scooted over to me, slow at first, but soon moving faster. I was confused, but once he wrapped his arms around my shoulders that confusion was eradicated. Something about feeling the warmth from his skin wrapped around me, something about his warm breath against my hair, something about how strong he was, made me realise.

"I love you."
The words came out before they even crossed my mind. My stomach felt as though it had dropped right down to my feet and my heart felt like it was being squeezed in someone's hand.

But then we shared that look.

A side glance, me looking to my left and him to his right, into each other's eyes. Love was coming from a place deep inside of both of us and showing itself in our expressions, our lips curling into a smile in unison. That was also the first time I understood him.

'I love you.'
He said, hugging me tighter. And we've been together ever since.

~

I flinch when Rogelio kicks off his boots and slides in beside me, wiggling up behind me and resting his chin on my head.

'You ok?'
To be honest, I don't know anymore. I don't think anyone's ok.

"Yeah."
I reach back and run my fingers along his jawline. I'm not sure how I discovered it, but this is one of those things that helps me

when I'm feeling down. Most things I do to calm down involve Rogelio. Surprise surprise!

I feel one of his strong arms wrap around me and I finally crack a smile.

"You make me feel safe."
I whisper. He hugs me tighter and I wiggle backwards so that I can feel his breaths.

Within minutes, I've drifted off into a dreamless slumber.

# Four

Kyle's POV

"We're raiding the village."
She said. I looked around at the other cadets in confusion.

"Why?"
It was bold of me to ask, but sometimes I felt brave. Catra glared at me and slammed the table, her claws digging into the fresh metal and creating a jarring scraping sound.

"We have to send a message to them. To her."
She said. Her voice was strangled and and I could see the hurt in her eyes, but that was no excuse.

"They're innocent people!"
I replied. Rogelio and Lonnie shared a look of surprise, but I didn't care, not when Catra was going to force us to capture the innocent. Then she did it. I think I understand why she did.

It was only a scratch, a small gash at the very most, but it bled like crazy. Almost the second she did it her eyes widened and a look of regret took over. Of course she was too proud to apologise, but I could tell she was sorry.

Rogelio got all worried, whisking me off to clean and bandage up my arm, all while I listened to Lonnie shout at our force captain. It was touching how much they cared, but I knew Catra was struggling with something. Now I finally understand what it was she was struggling with.

~

I wake up and instantly sit upright, clutching the sheets around me and bowing my head to catch my breath. The sky is an orangey-pink, and Rogelio is still snoring, so I quietly lift the blankets and swing my legs over the edge of the bed, standing up

and silently making my way outside. I'm used to waking up in the early morning.

I have to pull the wedge out from under the door and it opens with a creak, but I don't wake anybody up, so I let out a breath of relief.

I've always loved the peace of the Crimson Waste. I love the silence that envelops the place all night, I love the soft heat that fills the air, and the feeling of being isolated yet surrounded by people close to you. Sure, there are some dangerous residents, but they tend to stay away from us. Maybe they know how much training we've been through.

I decide to walk down the street, like I always do. My feet are bare but the ground is hot from the sun, so I won't be cold. Some windows are open, or as open as they can be at least. Most of us just have a single sheet of plastic stuck into the walls opening.

This is usually the time I feel most comfortable with myself. Take now, for example. I'm wearing grey sweatpants that I just slept in, my shirt is one of my old cadet ones and my hair is a mess. But nobody cares when the sun hasn't fully risen yet.

Maybe I should be embarrassed, maybe I should worry about what people will think. But what is there to to judge?

They know I was a soldier. They know I'm a friend of Adora's, and of Bright Moon in general. They know what I've been through. Besides, I don't have time to worry about my status in the waste when I can't even get out of my own head.

"Morning Kyle!"
A raspy voice calls. I turn to it's owner and smile.

"Morning."
I nod, and keep walking. It gets tedious after repeating this cycle for weeks on end. An older man with curled goat horns and soft beige skin smiles at me and I smile back.

When I finally get to where I was heading, I take it in like it's my first time here. It's a small clearing outside the tall blocks of flats, away from the bustle of people and away from stress of every day.

It's not appealing to most people, the red sand that floats in the air tastes gross and the shrubs that protrude from under the rocks are dry and dead looking, you can literally see the heat on the horizon and you can never be sure of who's lurking outside the town limits. I like it.

I decide to sit on a large grey rock to think.

Bird song in the distance reminds me of when I was younger. There weren't much living things in the Fright Zone that weren't soldiers of some kind, except for birds. They would come on flocks of ten or eleven at a time, soaring above us when we trained or landing on our machinery when we were on guard.

They were the only things I knew to be free, that's why when Adora left I was so confused. I didn't know there could be a life for us beyond the walls of the Fright Zone.

My eyes wander to the floor, surveying the dirt on my feet and the weeds between my toes, when I notice something glistening in the sand.

Without thinking, I lower my hand towards the glimmer, almost certain that it's money of some kind. But then I pull it out.

I look down to what's in my hand and feel my breath hitch in my throat. A scarlet-red crystal with twelve or so sides rests in the palm of my hand, a white message etched into its edge in a form of symbols and runes.

Just like the one that Catra found.

# Five

Kyle's POV

"What is it? What do they mean?"
I say in panic, pacing the floor of our bedroom and biting my nails. My fingers feel raw, but I keep on gnawing away in worry. Rogelio flips the crystal around in his hands and looks at me with a concerned expression. He says something but I can't understand him. Why can't I understand him?

"I-I don't know what you're s-saying!"
I stutter, still pacing. He frowns and reaches out to me, obviously to take my hand, but for some reason I flinch and pull away. He raises his eyebrows and I feel all the guilt in the world piling onto my shoulders. What the hell is wrong with me?

'Try to relax.'
Ro says, and this time I can hear him, only now I wish I couldn't.

"Relax? First Catra finds a crystal telling us that somebody is coming for us, and now we find another one that probably says something worse? And in the Crimson Waste, our home? How am I meant to relax?!"
I'm a bit taken aback by my outburst but Rogelio looks calm. I stop my obsessive pacing and hold my hand out to him, which he instantly takes. When he smiles I almost forget about the potentially life-threatening message in his other hand.

"Sorry."
I whisper. He shakes his head and pulls me closer to him so that we're only inches apart.

'You don't have to be sorry.'
Maybe that's all I needed to hear right now, or maybe he's the only one I needed to be with right now, but either way I feel a little lighter. I sit beside him and take the crystal into my own hands, letting it rest in my palms.

"I guess we should tell Adora about this."
Rogelio nods and closes my fingers around the crystal, the ominous message etched into it's side now hidden beneath my touch. My skin feels hot where he touched me, like those first times we held hands, and I feel even calmer yet again. Oh, Rogelio. You've got such a strong effect on me that all you need to do is breathe and my world stops spinning. Do you even know that?

'I'll let her know.'
Rogelio says, reaching out for his soldier communicator. As cadets we all got one each, and we use them for emergencies. I don't like to spend too much time looking at devices that brought us so much pain as children.

Watching him type a message into the small piece of technology brings back a flood of memories that I never expected to be brought back.

~

I was in the bottom bunk, with Lonnie sleeping just above me. Adora was sleeping with Catra at her feet to my right, and Rogelio was to my left. I lay facing him with a smile.

We were only fifteen then, way younger and way wilder than I would ever imagine being now. Ro had opened his mouth to day something, but knew that I couldn't understand him so smiled back at me instead.

I stretched my arm out towards him and let it rest on the cold floor between us. He did the same, and our hands were joined together for a moment before footsteps echoed out in the corridor and our hands broke apart in an instant. Then I had an idea.

I took out my communicator and began to type. Rogelio watched in amusement as I did so. We were very close at fifteen, and being as hormonal as we were even the slightest of actions could end catastrophically.

'I wish I could lie with you'
I sent the message with a tugging feeling in my stomach. He took out his communicator and read it with a smile, his face illuminated from the soft light of the screen and making him look even more perfect than I had previously perceived him as.

'someday u can, I promise'

~

"Remember when we used to send messages to each other at night time with those?"
I ask, snapping out of my trance and slowly adjusting back to reality. Rogelio switches off the small device, obviously after sending the message, and smiles at me.

'Of course I remember.'
He growls. I let out a shaky sigh.

"We could have done it. You and me, we could have shared the bed."
My words are quiet but linger in the air. Ro lifts his hand to stroke my cheek and his eyes flit over everything from my hair to my nose, staring longest at my lips.

'We were young, and...'
I don't understand the last word he says, but I don't think I need to. I tilt my head upwards and kiss him gently, to which he smiles and embraces me in a tight hug.

"Look, this whole crystal thing could be dangerous. We're going to work it out together, right?"
I ask. Rogelio rests his chin on the top of my head.

'Me and you together. That's never going to change.'
We hear a knock on the door and seconds later Glimmer is calling out to us.

"Kyle? Rogelio? It's Glimmer!"
We both answer the door and she hastily grabs us by our hands.

Her palms are sweaty in what looks like stress, and her hair is styled to look how it used to before she became queen.

"No time to lose. The more crystals we have, the more answers we can find."
She pants between breaths. She notices the crystal in Rogelio's free hand and tilts her head to the side.

"Everybody's at the castle."

# Chapter 6

Rogelio's POV

Someday, we'll all be gone.

Someday, the lights will go out and the world will go dark. All of our fighting will have been for nothing, all of our loving... for nothing. So why am I so scared? Why is it that when I sit at this table with the others, all I can think about is keeping him safe?

Why does he come to mind when Bow explains what's going on? Why, even though one day everything I know will cease to exist, all I want to do is make sure he's okay?

"It says they want Adora."
Bow sets the crystal that Kyle found on the table and his words bounce around my brain like a ball on a tennis court- repeatedly. Adora herself winces a little, but not for long. She was obviously expecting this. Catra and Glimmer on the other hand, look livid.

"What?"
Catra exclaims, her ears pricking upwards. Glimmer's mouth is hanging agape in shock. The other princesses look confused and upset, and Kyle is wearing a look of worry. I probably look serious as always, but inside I'm just as surprised as everyone else. Adora stands up, pulls out a small scroll of paper from her sleeve and rolls it out onto the table before us all.

The parchment itself is old and yellowed from wear, and the black mass of ink scrawled on top of it is unmistakably Adora's handwriting. Perfuma shakes her head and stands up, making some heads turn.

"Don't tell me you were planning for this?"
She asks. Frosta nods beside her, and I can't help but notice how different she looks since I last saw her as a young child. Adora sighs and starts to read the scroll.

"The messages we have received are from the first ones, most definitely. Their ancient code is identical to the codes found on She-Ra's sword, and the crystals that were used for the messages were formed at the same year as the ones found in certain parts of Mara's ship."
Mermista folds her arms.

"Adora, come on. The first ones have been dead for centuries."
She says. Scorpia shakes her head with a pained expression in reply.

"No. Entrapta and I helped Adora test the crystals. She's right."
I look down to Kyle and am somewhat relieved that he looks as clueless as I am. Despite the bonding and friendships that have formed over the past few years between us and the others here, we're still outsiders. Scorpia, Catra and Adora are the only ones who we can barely relate to.

Adora clears her throat and everybody reluctantly lets her continue.

"My whole life was built around the existence of the first ones. They could be my family, the ones who sent me to Etheria, or the ones who made it my destiny to be She-Ra. And..."
She pauses for a moment and takes a quick glance at Catra, who's watching her with all the worry in the world.

"They want me, and I want to find answers. I need to find answers. So-"
Kyle interrupts her, and makes everybody turn to him. My stomach squirms at the sudden attention.

"Adora, you can't go to them alone."
He says. Adora sighs and sits down.

"How did you know I was going to say that?"
She asks. Kyle shrugs and smiles a little in her direction.

"We grew up together, and giving yourself up to protect others is a very Adora thing to do."

Everyone nods and Catra places a hand over Adora's with teary eyes.

"No. You can't keep sacrificing yourself!"
She pleads. I can see the genuine love in her eyes and it almost scares me, because it reminds me of myself. The love in her eyes reminds me of Kyle. And what's even more amazing is that although she looks afraid, terrified, even, but her pure admiration for Adora has overpowered that fear. Her and Adora have been through so much... why do they deserve any more pain?

'We can't let Adora go on her own, if at all.'
I say. Kyle translates for me.

"He says we can't let Adora go. Not on her own, at least."
Bow nods and so does Glimmer, but Adora herself looks almost... mad.

"I get that you all want to protect me. It's sweet, and heartwarming, honestly it is. But I have to find out about where I came from."
She says. I sigh quietly. Classic Adora. Thankfully Perfuma comes to everyone's aid and tells her what we're all thinking.

"You have every right to want to know about your family. But we have to come up with a plan to keep you safe! That means waiting for more information from whoever this is."
Adora nods and Glimmer claps her hands and stands up with an anxious but warm smile.

"It's way too late for us to start planning, and I'm out of magic for today, so you guys can stay here for the night if you want to. We're going to start preparing first thing in the morning."
I look at Kyle and see how heavy his eyelids look. He smiles at me in what can only be relief. Everybody gets up and starts to talk amongst themselves.

"We're lucky I went on that walk this morning, huh?"
Kyle says, and I can only smile. Then his expression turns to sadness, or guilt of some kind.

"I get they want us to help because we're the only ones in the Waste, but..."
He looks around to make sure everyone is still chatting before leaning in a little closer.

"We're the only ones without powers. I mean, Bow has his arrows, and Sea-Hawk is a really skilled sailor. We have nothing except fighting. Everybody here is good at fighting. Well, except for me..."
I want to reply, but a hand on his shoulder distracts us both.

"You aren't useless, you know."
Catra says with a smile.

"I get what you mean. I don't have powers, either. My only skill is hand to hand combat, like you guys, with some claws and agility added in. But what if the princesses can't use their powers? What if something happens to She-Ra's sword? We're going to be there to save the day."

She smiles up at me before turning on her heels and going back over to Adora. I guess she's right. Within no time Glimmer has given us a room and we get into bed without bothering to change.

"You know, I'm proud of us. We stuck with the Horde our whole lives, fighting the good guys, but now we're helping them."

Kyle says. I nod and close my eyes.

We're good guys now.

# seven

Kyle's POV

We're all sitting at the big table again, ready to plan for the worst. I feel a little worried, but it's not too bad when Ro is next to me. Glimmer is more or less leading the discussion.

"We can't act until we know why they want you!"
She exclaims, half way through her protective argument with Adora, who frowns and folds her arms.

"We can try-"
She starts, but Bow cuts her off.

"No! We don't even know where this random person wants you to go! We have to wait for more information!"
They all start to argue some more and I smile at Rogelio, who's watching with a perplexed but equally amused expression. We've been watching from the sidelines for a while now.

"We can't spend all this time hoping that they give us instructions. We have to do something!"
Now Catra chimes in, her ears standing upwards when the others stop to listen.

"Adora, please, we just want to protect you!"
Aaaaand more arguing. They're talking so loudly that they don't notice Micah walking in with something in his hands.

Everybody who wasn't part of the full blown shout fest turns to him and he leaves a scroll of paper on the table before us and whispers something.

"This was on the doorstep for you guys."
Me and Rogelio move over to where the others are seated and read the paper with them while Adora and the others continue to blab.

A couple of frightening words flash before my eyes, swimming to the surface amongst the sea of first ones symbols.

'war'
'peace'
'fighting'
'hate'
'family'

Eventually the four of them stop giving out to each other and look over to all of us. They soon huddle around, also craning their necks to read the letter. Adora takes it into her hands and reads it, a stern look on her face.

"Dear Adora and friends..."
This first sentence isn't very assuring. Even though I only skimmed the page I have a really bad feeling about this message.

"I invite you all to a friendly ball in my ship. It will give me the time to get to know you all... and get to know my own Adora..."
Adora puts the parchment down and looks at all of us with a frown. Scorpia beams at us all.

"A ball sounds nice... maybe they genuinely want to get to know us."
She says with a hopeful glint in her eyes. My stomach squirms with nerves but I kind of agree. I've never been to a ball, only when we were sent to sabotage Frosta's princess prom... but I know they're used to show peace or to celebrate. Sea-Hawk scratches his head for a minute but then pipes in.

"Well, Adora, if you really want to know about this person this would probably be a good start."
A couple of us nod. I notice Rogelio isn't trying to say anything and I look at him to check he's ok, but it looks like he's just listening to everyone else's opinions first.

"Does it say where the ship is?"
Frosta asks. Adora picks the scroll up again and nods.

"They said it's on a mountain top over some desert... there's a city nearby but the ship is on an area of red sand."
Oh no. Rogelio and I look at each other instantly and I can see the dread in his eyes, but it surely can't match with the pure anxiety racing around my body right now. I know that certain place particularly well.

"It's the Crimson Waste. The ship is on the mountain that we can see from the street."
I say. I'm not sure why it freaks me out, but I think it's something to do with the fact that we have no idea who this person is or what they could do to the Waste of something went wrong. Catra nods and looks over Adora's shoulder to read some more.

"Tomorrow at eight pm sharp."
She reads. Perfuma looks kind of excited, but I can see hints of stress peeking through her smile.

"I think we should go. All of us. She asked for friends of Adora, and all of you are my friends."
Adora states, rolling up the scroll and tucking it under her arm. We all nod but I don't feel fully on board, because we're going to the ship of some foreign alien who knows the language that the first ones spoke, and that's pretty terrifying. She turns to me and Rogelio.

"You guys need to make sure they don't try to pull anything from today until tomorrow, got it?"
We both nod, but my head hurts. I see images of the Fright Zone, visions of my old uniform, and memories of fighting in the war. And gunshots... gunshots that are really, really loud...

I feel a hand on my shoulder and jump out of my old nightmares. No. I have to help my friends, and letting those memories take over will just ruin everything.

"O-okay, sure.”
Everybody seems content but then Perfuma shakes her head and

stands up, the shawl draped over her arms billowing slightly with her movement.

"Guys... I know we all want to find out who this is. I know Adora wants answers, but think about this. An unknown source telling us that we need to watch out because they're coming, then a creepy message saying that they want Adora?"
She looks around for somebody to agree with her. Mermista sighs.

"Yeah, it's kinda weird. It's like the most obvious trap ever."
She says. I'm not sure who's side to take, so I stay quiet. Maybe they'll resolve this so I can stop thinking about the worst that could happen. Glimmer is hugging herself and staring at the table with a pained look in her eyes when she states her case.

"It seems like a friendly gesture to me... what's the worst that could happen at a ball? As long as we come prepared..."
She says. A couple of eyes land on me, Rogelio and Scorpia for obvious reasons and I feel my cheeks burning up. Bow is next to speak.

"I agree with Perfuma."
Glimmer wrinkles her nose when he says this.

"It's all a bit too easy. How do we know it's not a ploy to trap us all in there?"
Arguing breaks out in a wave, sweeping over each and every person in the room until nobody except Rogelio and I are left silent. Their voices fill my head, their words bouncing around the room and into my ears. Why is everything so  loud? Rogelio is asking me something but I can only hear growls. I can't understand him...

I try to focus on what he's saying, wincing in hope that the voices of the others will dim down, but they don't. And then it gets louder. I can still hear arguing, but not from those in the room. It's the voice of Lonnie and Catra. I can hear Shadow Weaver yelling at us, telling me i'm useless. When I look at Rogelio he's

wearing his cadet uniform again, and we're not in the room anymore, but in the Fright Zone. I can still hear them fighting.

Why... why can't I hear anything... why are they so loud... why won't the flashbacks go away...

A different kind of yelling fills my ears now, and I can't pay attention to the real people in front of me. I see people on the ground, smoke and ash drifting through the air around them. I see broken buildings and piles of rubble, but the screams are what haunt me. Horrible, strangled screams from people being separated from their families and taken away from their homes. We were responsible for that. I want to come back to reality but the screaming is getting louder, more real...

Rogelio's POV

Kyle stands up all of a sudden, making me flinch. Without anybody noticing except myself he slips out of the room with his head down, staring at the lifeless ground. I instantly follow him without detection and leave the heated discussion behind.

Out in the tall and empty hallway the noise of everybody arguing is muffled, but still present, like being in a house next to the ocean, where the waves are still creating soft crashes against the shore, but they're not loud enough to fill your ears.

I follow the sound of soft footsteps clicking against the crystal floor until they stop, telling me he went outside. I find him in the garden sitting on a small bench made of marble. He says nothing when I sit next to him, but a single tear rolls down his cheek.

'Are you seeing things again?'
I ask. I know he can't concentrate on understanding me when he's upset, but he takes my hand and interlocks his fingers with mine like he can. It's a little scary to see somebody you know and love with such lifeless eyes and such an exhausted expression, but it must be much worse for him. He opens his mouth and croaks

out something that I can't hear. Is this what it feels like to talk to me all the time?

'I don't... I don't understand you...'
Another tear falls down his face and he falls gently to the side so that his head rests on my shoulder. I've learned that in these situations it's best to let him think. Nobody can push through the memories except him, so there's no point in prying or stressing him out.

I hear footsteps and turn my head a little to see Scorpia. She smiles and sits beside me.

"Saw you guys leaving... is everything ok?"
I nod towards the crying boy to my other side and she sighs.

"They uh... decided. We're going to the ball, with weapons ready of course. You guys are invited if you want to come. We kind of need all the back up we can get."
She says. Kyle sits up and wipes his eyes with the back of his hands. I want to ask if he's ok, but I'll probably get his usual lie in response, 'I'm fine', so I let him speak.

"We'll be there. The ship is right beside our home, and we- I- cant keep hiding from things my whole life."
He says, smiling at us both. I smile back at him and Scorpia claps her pincers together in excitement.

"Yay! Oh, i'm so excited! I mean, no. It's not a party. It's just a way to get information!"
She hops up from her seat and makes her way back to the castle, but when I turn to look at her, she spins on her heels and waves at us.

"I'm always here to talk, you guys!"
And she goes back inside. I turn to Kyle and expect to see him smiling, but instead I see him look  little frightened instead.

"Ro? The flashbacks... they're getting worse."

# Chapter 8

Kyle's POV  (Going to be a very long chapter!)

I stand in front of the mirror with a frown on my face. The outfit I'm wearing is one of my favorites, since it's the most expensive thing I own. There's sky blue trousers that stop at my ankles, a matching blazer and a soft white shirt that's smooth to the touch. My shoes are an inky black and they don't have a single scuff, probably because I've only ever worn them once.

I'm supposed to be looking forward to making peace with the new person in the ship, but I can't stop thinking about what happened yesterday. The memories that flooded back to me because of nothing but a silly argument.

'You look nice.'
Rogelio says, stepping behind me so that I can see him in the mirror. He has a similar outfit to mine, only his is black, not blue, but he has bow tie left untied around his neck that matches what I'm wearing.

"As do you."
I say with a smile. He ties my own black bow tie and I can't help but smile at the final result. I look... good. I offer to tie his but he shakes his head.

'I saw Catra wear it open before, I think it's cool.'
He says. I shove him playfully and roll my eyes. He copies everything Catra does, but I don't blame him honestly.

I sigh and look over at the clock on the dresser. 7:20pm.

"It's nearly time."
I say. My voice cracks with anxiety. I'm not one for formal gatherings, and I'm definitely not one for fighting. I know we're supposed to be positive going in here, but after fighting a war I've

lost trust in a lot of people. I'm going in preparing for the absolute worst.

Rogelio nods and takes both of our staffs that we got as soldiers into a carrier strap on his back and I laugh a little.

"Is that allowed?"
He shrugs.

'If the princesses have their powers, then we have to be ready, too.'
We both smile for what feels like hours, but was actually only seconds. I walk out into the living room and peek out of the window, biting my lip subconsciously. The sky is getting dark, which means that everybody will be picking up soon. I pick up the rusty key from the windowsill and flip it over in my hand. We only lock the door from the outside when we leave at night, and that's very rare.

I notice some silhouettes on top of the hill where the ship is. The ship itself must be on the other side, because we can't see it from here.

"There's some people up there already. Should we go?"
I ask. Rogelio peeks out the window over my head and sighs.

'Yeah, we should.'
We open the door and try not to choke on the hot sandy air blown into our faces. My fingers fumble when I try to lock the door with the stupid old key and I get so frustrated Rogelio has to take over so that I don't break it. I notice the shadows on the hill are waving towards us, and I don't even know who it is but I wave back.

The walk to the peak is long and draining. With the heat hanging in the air and the sand slowing us down everything is harder than expected. I start to see some one, probably whoever was waving, and feel somewhat relieved when I see Catra and Adora smiling at us.

They run over to us and Catra compliments Rogelio's bow tie while I internally cringe.

"Hey, Kyle. You okay?"
Adora asks. I smile and nod, not ready to explain anything yet. I want to talk to her, but I also want to see this ship, so I look around to find it. It doesn't take long at all before it comes into focus, huge, possibly even bigger in width than the castle of Bright Moon itself, with a silver metal body and some kind of exterior decoration made from crystals embedded into it. It's a wonder we couldn't see it from our window because of how massive it is. Adora smiles.

"Nice, huh?"
She asks. I nod and turn back to Rogelio to show him, but he's already standing next to me admiring the view. Catra lets out a sigh and props her elbow up onto Adora's shoulder.

"I like the way you two are matching. It's cute."
She says, her eyes staying focused on the ship. We mumble some embarrassed 'thanks' and I'm personally delighted and relieved when I hear more voices from people trudging up the hill to meet us.

"Hey guys! Wow, blue really is your colour, Kyle!"
Scorpia says, running towards us. I go red and smile at her. After a couple of minutes everybody else gets here, and we all linger around, glancing at the ship from time to time.

"Well, let's go."
Mermista says, looping her arm around Sea-Hawk's. Everybody agrees and we make our way to the large square in the ship that looks like a door. It's so big that there's probably a whole dance hall inside and we can't even see it yet. I notice Bow has is bow and arrows on his back and let out a sigh of relief. I notice also that Adora has a golden cuff around her wrist, which means she has the sword.

We all came prepared.

Adora knocks on the ship and we wait for what feels like ages before a loud grating sound rings out over the hill, and the door grinds open slowly. When it finally comes down to touch the ground, we can see lights of all colours reflecting off crystals and filling what looks like a corridor with bright light. The walls inside have a white marble-like texture, and the floor is a light grey colour.

"Let's go."
Adora says quietly. She takes Catra's hand and steps hesitantly into the ship. We all follow with light steps, almost afraid that if we tread too hard we could crack the pristine floor. I move closer to Rogelio and wrap my fingers around his when the door lifts itself up and clicks shut while I feel jitters in my stomach.

"Welcome, friends of Adora."
A female voice says from an unknown source. If Entrapta were here, maybe she would be able to figure out where it's coming from. The voice travels throughout the corridor and bounces back to us like an echo. I feel Rogelio's grip on my hand tighten.

"Please make your way down the corridor to the left, where you'll find the ballroom. I am ever so excited for your visit!"
The woman sounds cheery, which is somewhat assuring, but I don't feel fully safe yet. We all move in a group to the left and towards a large set of pearly white double doors. Adora leads us as usual, but I can tell she's nervous too. The doors swing open and I can't do anything but stare with my mouth slightly open in awe.

There's a large hall, huge actually, with a tall ceiling and decorative crystal lamps and ornaments strung along the blindingly white walls. The floor is grey, much like the corridor, and the smell of chocolate and punch is potent in the air. I notice there's some movement going on and my eyes widen even further when i see them. There's some kind of waiters in the hall, tall and slim, made from transparent pink and orange rock. They have no face, except for eyes, which appear to be moving in accordance to what they're thinking.

None of us move until another set of doors opposite us open and a small woman with pale blue skin and a head of long white hair sashays out, a white fur shawl draped around her shoulders that contrasts nicely with her black dress. She wears a friendly smile, but anybody could hide behind a mask like that. I do it all the time.

"Oh, aren't you dashing!"
The woman says, opening her arms wide and clicking her way over to Bow. He smiles politely and she winks at him which makes us all uncomfortable.

"All of you are welcome here. Please, don't be shy! Dance away!"
This sounds more like a command than an offer. Adora turns to us all and nods as if to say 'Go on', so we make our way further into the beautiful room. The woman leads Catra and Adora to a table at the back of the room and they sit down, presumably to talk about what her deal is.

The rest of us move off into the hall and linger awkwardly in a group, forming a sort of weird huddle without realising. Sea-Hawk looks over his shoulder towards Catra and Adora and then turns back to the group with a concerned expression.

"We have to be prepared to fight. There's something... off about this place."
We nod to each other in agreement and Perfuma opens her mouth to add something, but she's interrupted when one of the glass waiters taps her on the shoulder. It points to where the woman who owns the ship is standing and so we all turn to face her.

The golden bangles she has slung on her arms clink together as she raises her arms out towards us. Behind her, Catra and Adora share a nervous look.

"Didn't you hear me? Dance away!"
This time her message sounds much more threatening, and out of

instinct I grab Rogelio's hand. Whenever i'm scared, one thing is always true- he'll be there for me.

I can see out of the corner of my eye that the others have started to dance with each other. I guess nobody wants to go against what this lady says. Scorpia shoots me a nervous look and so I wrap my arms around Ro's neck without hesitation. He puts his hands on my waist and we start to move in sync with the music that's being played from somewhere, presumably a speaker of some kind. The sound of a violin rings out through the hall, followed by some piano and an eery voice that sings with the rhythm.

"This is really weird."
I say quietly. Rogelio nods and looks around at the others, who look equally as freaked out.

'Let's just talk to pass the time.'
I nod and try not to look at Catra and Adora, ago are talking to the woman with serious expressions.

"So... you're tall."
I say. Rogelio laughs and nods.

'You're small.'
I see one of the shiny waiter things looking at me and I quickly flit my eyes away from it and back to Rogelio.

"I'm no good at this. I can't dance."
I mutter. Ro nods to his left and I follow the nod to Glimmer and Bow, who are standing on each other's toes repeatedly and smacking into Perfuma and Scorpia. Frosta had to stay home because she's too young to put at risk, but I can almost hear her telling them to stop.

The music speeds up but nobody dancing does. We just stay spinning in pointless and tedious circles, locked in embraces that do nothing but put us at a disadvantage in the case of a fight.

'Any flashbacks today?'
Rogelio asks. I shake my head and smile at the floor.

"No, not today. I think I got it all out of my system yesterday."
He nods at my response and says something, but I notice a waiter standing behind him and have to stare at it. We spin around and Ro stares at it, too.

"What is it doing?"
I whisper. He shrugs, his eyes still trained on it's face.

'I think you should be ready to grab the staff.'
He says quietly. I nod and rest my head on his chest so that we're hugging, making it easier to move my hands to one of the metal rods on his back. I feel sick to my stomach when I see that there's a waiter beside every pair on the floor. But somebody's missing... no, two people are missing...

"Where are Catra and Adora?"
I hiss into Rogelio's ear. I feel him stiffen and that's when I know something is wrong. I don't even have to think before I pull the staff from his back and point it at the waiter's neck. Everybody breaks apart and looks at me like I'm insane, but I know what I'm doing.

"Where are they? What's that woman going to do with them?"
I ask. I'm not sure where this surge of confidence came from, but I think it could be linked to the flashbacks I keep getting. Unfortunately any sign of danger, no matter how big or small, sends me into fight mode. In this situation it could be useful.

The lights flicker and the room goes dim, the waiters now the only thing providing light with their soft glow that radiates from their abdomens. I hear the sound of Bow sliding an arrow from it's sheath at the other side of the hall.

The waiter grabs my staff and throws it to the ground, creating a loud clanging noise for everyone to hear, then it sticks a cold, pointed finger to my neck and lifts my chin up to face it. I srunch

my nose up in a twisted scowl, but it only tilts it's head at me. Rogelio attempts to grab it but another crystalised waiter grabs him by the arms and restrains him.

"What a pity."
It says. It's the woman's voice, only more broken and static. Then the one holding my chin up speaks, too, as if it was speaking all along.

"You two love each other. As the saying goes... till death do we part."
A deafening crash somewhere in the room tells us somebody's thrown the first punch. I duck and Rogelio breaks free and smashes his staff into the waiter's glass arm, shattering it off onto the floor. Shards of glass stick into my face but I don't have time to take them out.

"Find the doors! That's where she took them!"
Perfuma shouts. We all run in the direction of the large doors that the woman came through, stumbling through the darkness and hitting the waiters that plunge at us from all directions.

I see a flash of pink and expect Glimmer to teleport but nothing happens, so she resorts to running over and swinging the door open, allowing a wave of white light to flood into the hall again. We rush through the doors and halt to a stop when we meet Catra and Adora, standing with the woman between them. They look unharmed, but Adora is mouthing something. You'd think after years of making out what Rogelio is saying I would be able to read her lips, but I can't.

"Oh, what's this? We were coming back, you know."
The woman sings. I gulp and try to focus on what Adora is saying.

'Run'
Perfuma balls her hands into fists and a green glow envelops them as she glares at the woman, but nothing else happens. Why are the princesses' powers not working?

"What's happening? Why did they attack us?"
She asks. Her voice cracks and hints of anger can be heard. The woman looks confused.

Adora mouths 'run' again and stares into my eyes, making me feel like I could vomit on the spot with how nervous I am. My face stings where the glass cut me, but that's not important. I see another glass waiter coming up behind Catra and go to warn her, but instead she screams out to us all with a strangled and hoarse cry;

"RUN! GET OUT OF HERE!"
We're all pushed out into the hall again and the doors slam shut. I can still hear Catra on the other side screaming for us to leave.

"Do we go? Do we save them?"
Mermista asks. We all look around desperately for an answer but we eventually come to an unspoken agreement. We have to get out of here. We can plan to save them later.

We run back towards the door we came on through, hopping over the shards of glass and crystals that litter the floor as we do so. The crunches of the delicate material under our shoes fill my ears and threaten to trigger a flashback, but I don't let it happen.

Sweat is pumping from my forehead and I can feel my heart beating in my mouth as we near the exit. When we get out, without having to say anything we all grab onto each other and Glimmer teleports us away.

I feel something cold and hard under my head. My eyes flutter open slowly, and they take a while to adjust to the light of the castle that we've teleported back to. Groans ring out around me and I sit up to see everybody who escaped on the floor too.

Glimmer is the only one standing, and her eyes are glossy.

"It was a trap."
She says, a tear rolling down her cheek and falling to the floor. Then the reality of what just happened settles in.

"It was all a trap."

# Nine

Rogelio's POV

I carefully take the last of the glass shards from Kyle's skin and put it into the little dish next to us. He winces but tries to smile when I dab away the blood from his cuts. Guilt is the only emotion I can feel when I watch as his eyes become glossy with tears that threaten to fall.

'Sorry.'
I grumble. Nobody else can hear me because they're all busy talking and freaking out about what just happened. I don't really have time to freak out since I'm trying to stop my boyfriend's face from bleeding, but at the same time i'm still trying to process everything that we just experienced. Kyle shakes his head suddenly and reaches out to place a hand on the side of my face.

"If you didn't hit it, it would have hit me."
He says. I sigh and nod. He always understands me.

"I knew something was up when they made us dance! Why were we so scared? Why did we do what she said?!"
Glimmer exclaims, pacing back and forth from one wall in the room to another. Frosta is sitting on a chair, trying to catch up on what happened.

"It all went so... fast."
Bow says. I try to keep Kyle's attention on me, purely because if things get too heated he could zone out again. Although he did get through a fight...

"What're you thinking about?"
He asks, taking his hand from my face and propping his chin on it instead. I shrug and put the dish of bloody glass onto the table next to me.

'Just worried.'
He looks over at Scorpia, who's sitting with her elbows on her knees and her head bowed. Perfuma is patting her on the back.

"We'll get through this, all of us. We always find a solution."
He says to me. His voice is quiet, but still so loud somehow, lingering in my head long after he stops speaking. What he doesn't understand is that while i'm beginning to worry more and more about Catra and Adora, I want to worry about him.

I've never stopped trying to protect him since we were kids, but he's always so keen on handling everything on his own. I know he's his own person, and that he can protect himself, but there's something inside of me that drives me to putting him before anything else. Now that there's a big and more dangerous issue present, I'm worried that he'll get lost in his mind again.

I try to put my hands on my lap but instead I feel a horrible, sharp stinging sensation in my palms. I look at them and see big pieces of crystal sticking from them. Kyle's eyebrows rise and he instantly grabs the tweezers I was using to take the glass out of his face.

'You're hurt, it's ok'
I say, but he doesn't listen. He slowly takes hold of one of the spiky chunks and pulls it out. I squeeze my eyes shut with agony. This might just be most pain I've ever been in. He gently takes out all of the shards and wipes my hands, before wrapping some gauze and a bandage around both of them.

'Thanks.'
He smiles at me and pecks a small kiss my cheek before turning to the conversation happening in the centre of the room.

"We need to plan."
Frosta says. The others nod but Sea-Hawk shakes his head.

"But where do we start?"
Everyone looks around for advice and I do too. Nobody knows

what to do.

"I don't think... I don't think our powers work in there."
Perfuma says. Glimmer nods and so does both Scorpia and Mermista.

"Yeah, I couldn't teleport."
Glimmer says. How are we supposed to get them out without magic? Bow frowns a little in concentration and sits at the table.

"We need to minimise the amount of people that to back there, so that we don't get caught. You guys, princesses I mean,"
He waves his hand in their general direction.

"Would probably be better off staying here. I promise it's nothing against you personally, it's just that I have my arrows, and Rogelio and Kyle are trained for this kind of thing. And if your kingdoms lose a leader..."
Glimmer sighs and sits next to him.

"You're right. I can't believe I'm saying this, but I think the ones without powers have to go in there."
She says. My stomach flips and churns when she says this. Just us? With no magic?

"Sea-Hawk, Ro, Kyle and Bow... you guys feel up to the task?"
Mermista asks. She looks each one of us up and down with obvious judgement. Scorpia shrugs.

"I can go, too. I was also trained by the Horde. And hey-"
She pinches her claws together in the air.

"Pincers!"

"Five of us is a little too risky. We should split into pairs, it'll be much more efficient."
Bow says. Sea-Hawk sighs before talking.

"Scorpia can take my place. I would love the adventure... bot she's had much more combat training and experience than I ever

did."
Scorpia smiles over at him and he returns the favour.

"Okay, so me and Scorpia will do it. Kyle, Rogelio?"
Kyle puts the roll of bandages in his hands onto the table and gives me a small smile before speaking up.

"We have to get Catra and Adora back. I'm in."
I nod to show that I'm in too. Perfuma claps her hands together in excitement and some flowers sprout up around her feet.

"Brilliant! Now we just need to come up with a plan."
I should be worried, I know. I should be upset about my two friends who were taken by that woman, and I am, really. But for once I'm feeling brave, and ready to fight for what's right, and It's a little... exhilarating.

But I know we can get them back.

# Ten

After attempting to get a good night's sleep, we all have clearer heads and more open mindsets for coming up wit a rescue plan. Yesterday when Catra and Adora were taken by the woman on the ship, I instantly blamed myself, and every time I think of them my heart likes to clench up and the hollow voice in my head likes to whisper things that could be happening to them because of us. Why won't they just shut-

"Kyle?"
Mermista asks. I don't think she's ever spoken to me directly before.

"Sorry, what?"
Scorpia smiles softly in my direction. Everybody looks in my direction, but we're so tired that nobody can focus. We're all still in our clothes that we wore to the ship, but we don't look fancy at all. Broken, dirty. Exhausted.

"You and Rogelio are taking the main entrance, while Bow and I take the rear."
I nod and try not to think about it too much. Adora and Catra are probably being tortured or something, and we're just sitting here trying to 'plan', so i'm not exactly feeling very cheery right now. Even if I try to pay attention i'm reminded of when we used to plan our attacks in the Horde, so it's not worth it. I'm not worth it. Anybody here would be better suited to this elaborate plan instead of me.

"Ok. There's a door at the back of the ship as well as at the front. I saw it when I was coming up the hill."
Scorpia says. We all nod, but then she looks a little worried.

"That's uh... all I know."
Oh. Perfuma stops her nervous hair braiding for a second and

stands up to speak.

"Hey, why don't we ask Entrapta for help? She probably knows something about the design of the ship."
The knot in my stomach loosens a bit.

"That's... actually a good idea."
Glimmer says. She looks at me and then to Scorpia with her eyebrows creased downwards in thought.

"We know where she lives, so who wants to go in there and ask her for help?"
I definitely do not. Going to Entrapta's means I'll have to see Hordak again, and I haven't seen him since their dumb wedding. He made us all think we were doing the right thing when we were against the rebellion, and I'm still not over it. Also, wearing the suit that I wore to the wedding is bound to bring back the sad memories of that awkward event.

Unfortunately for me, however, Rogelio and Entrapta have bonded a lot over the past few years. She's fascinated with his dialect and he always loved how smart she was, so of course they clicked. The bad part is that Rogelio has been trying to get me to visit her with him for months, but i've been avoiding it because of a certain someone who lives with her.

Naturally it shouldn't shock me when he raises his hand to volunteer to go, but it does.

Glimmer smiles at him and looks around for somebody else to go, too. Scorpia's so excited that it would be cruel to make her stay at the castle, so she's going too. Glimmer nods and they're teleported away quicker than I can blink.

The pit of my stomach feels heavy and gross when I realise they're gone. Besides Bow, I barely know anybody in the room. Sure, it's been years since the divide between our worlds was broken down, but that doesn't guarantee friendship between me and the princesses.

I've tried, and I want to know them better, but my anxiety and crippling fear of judgement have been quite the obstacles. Since we live so far away nobody really bothers us, and I used to be grateful for that because it meant I didn't have to feel guilty about the things I did with the Horde, but now i'm kind of wishing I had tried a little harder. Bow looks at me from across the table and smiles. It's a small gesture, but a meaningful one all the same. Just like when we spoke while he was in the cell years ago.

I smile back.

Rogelio's POV

Scorpia and I stand with smiles outside a large cream cottage with purple shutters on it's windows. Butterflies dance in the air around our heads and the lush grass flows around our feet as Scorpia knocks on the door. It's not what I expected when I first came to visit, but after being here a couple of times it's gotten familiar.

Despite the gentle and calming appearance of the house, there's a lot more complications and such beneath the surface. For example, if you look closely enough at the window frames you'll see tiny blinking lights where the mechanics are Entrapta has installed wires. The wires connect to all sorts of things inside the house, from the couch to the rug underneath it.

Maybe Kyle has a point making fun of my weird obsession with robotics.

At the other end of the garden I can see Hordak on his knees, digging what I presume to be holes for seeds to be dropped in. He turns around for a moment and smiles, but not for too long. It's all still a little fresh.

After a few clicks and whirs the door opens itself, swinging into the house and revealing a bright interior of whites and purples. Entrapta runs to the door with a huge smile.

"Yay! My two tallest friends!"
She squeals, using her hair to stand taller than she actually is. We

both smile at her and she runs over and pushes us inside. The smell of cakes and fresh metal fills the air, a strange combination but a suiting one for this house in particular. She pushes us both onto the couch and sits on the metal table opposite us.

"What brings you here? You need a new security system?"
She asks, one of her pigtails already latched around a blowtorch, but when I shake my head she puts it back with a frown.

"A huge ship landed in the Waste.  There's a woman inside, we think she has something to do with the first ones-"
Scorpia starts, but Entrapta claps her hands together before she can finish.

"You need a plan of the ship? Of course! I've got plans for all of the first ones' models so far!"
She slides off of the table and rummages around in the cabinets by the window, before pulling out a huge roll of blue paper. She spreads it out on the table. There's a floor plan for an entire ship on here, written and drawn in white ink. I can clearly see a long corridor and two main doors, with a large hall to the left.

'This is it.'
It's nice that there's someone else who can understand me now.
Entrapta squeals again and grabs another large sheet of paper, laying it on top. Scorpia raises her eyebrows.

"Is this-"

"The plan of the vents! You can go anywhere in the ship once you know the vents!"
I smile at both Entrapta's enthusiasm and how clever using the vents is.

"Why do you want to go inside, anyways?"
She asks. Scorpia and I share a nervous look before explaining what happened.

"The woman who landed here... she invited us all in. She made it kind of obvious she wanted us to dance, and we're not rude, so

we did. But while we weren't paying attention..."
Scorpia trails off and bows her head so I help her finish.

'They took Catra and Adora.'
Entrapta nods and waves a pigtail in our direction with seemingly no reaction at all.

"That explains the outfits..."
She quickly shakes her head and scratches her neck with an awkward smile.

"I mean, oh no! You guys better save them quick!"
Scorpia rolls up the sheets of paper and tucks them under her arm.

"Thanks so much, Entrapta. We would stay longer, but we don't have much time."
She says. Entrapta smiles and hugs us both one last time with her hair.

"It's ok, tell me everything about the vents when you get back!"

# Chapter 11

Kyle's POV

Moonlight seeps in through the windows perched high on the walls and rests on top of all of our heads. Despite getting the plans of the ship, and splitting us off into pairs, our plans to get Catra and Adora back haven't been developed very far, and everybody is getting restless.

"This must be where she's keeping them."
Glimmer says through a yawn, pressing her finger down on one of the sheets Entrapta gave us.

"There's only two other areas; the cockpit and loading dock, and this sort of bedroom thing that can only be hers."
Nobody feels awake enough to respond. With every passing minute the knot in my stomach grows tighter and tighter, worsening when I think of Catra and Adora and what could be going on in the ship, and it annoys me a little that we can't just storm in there to get them.

"I really hate to say this, and I know we can't waste our time, but we need to sleep. We can't stay up all night while we're exhausted."
Scorpia says, gently taking a sleeping Frosta into her arms. Despite being fourteen years old, she looks like a small child in Scorpia's strong embrace. I don't want to give up, but unfortunately the others in the group seem to disagree. Do they know what's at stake here? Although getting this moody is making me think that maybe I do need to rest...

"Okay, yeah. I think you should go back to your kingdoms for the night, just in case she tries to pull anything. Frosta can stay with us."
Bow says.

And so after a couple of trips with Glimmer, we're all back home, ready to protect our kingdoms and cities against the eerie ship on the hill.

I turn on the lamp in our bedroom and kick m shoes off into the corner of the room.

"I feel useless sitting here. Catra and Adora are literally just over there!"
I sigh, falling backwards onto the bed. Rogelio shrugs and does the same.

'If she wanted to take them, the ship would have flown away the second we left.'
He says, but I'm still scared. It's sort of satisfying to hear his voice after a long day of planning, but the satisfaction doesn't last long, given that I'm still an anxious wreck deep down. Some things never change. Rogelio rolls to his side and brushes a loose strand of hair from my eyes to behind my ears.

"I don't like this. We can't just sit here and do nothing."
I croak out. My skin feels hot when his hand leaves my face but he reaches out for my own hand instead, and when our fingers intertwine I feel the knot inside loosen.

'We have to work with the others. It's not our call.'
He grumbles.

"Nothing was ever our call."
These words come out as a quiet whimper, but he hears me.

'Just... try to sleep. We can go through everything tomorrow.'
I swing my legs over the edge of the bed, trudging over to where our staffs are propped up against the wall. When my fingers skim the cool metal rods I feel a small shiver that travels around my body. I remember when we used to train with these, and we used to stick them into robots and through the heart of holograms. I messed it up a lot, but somehow I still managed to build skill. I

guess I owe most of that to Rogelio. Maybe I owe it to him now to listen to what he's trying to say... but I still think it's wrong.

I look over at him and stifle a smile when I realise he's already gone. He looks so peaceful while sleeping, and all that muscle and tough skin, as intimidating as it can be, is suddenly insignificant.

I creep over and drape a blanket over him before crawling up and lying down, too.

I need to relax. Please, Kyle, just relax...

When I close my eyes, i'm transported into an old memory.

-

"Damn it, Kyle!"

Lonnie groaned, sliding across the floor of the training room. I was hanging from a crack in the tiles, and my chest plate was flashing red. I was only sixteen then, and I was prone to slipping up and ruining our training sessions. I could hear Rogelio saying something from somewhere, but it was Adora who took my hand and hauled me out.

I smiled at her as she helped me stand upright.

"Thanks."
I mumbled. She nodded and handed me my staff that I had dropped.

"I don't leave anyone behind."
I nodded and the holograms in the room switched off, telling us that we were done for the day. Lonnie glared at Adora as she ran to catch up with Catra.

"You have to pay attention. Adora and Rogelio won't always be there to save you."
I looked to the floor to stop myself from getting upset.

"You wouldn't save me?"
I asked. I regretted it immediately after I said it, and her response made everything worse.

"Look, Kyle. There's two types of soldiers- the ones who waste their time trying to help people who can't be helped, and the ones who get the job done. I don't like to waste time."
She said, shooting me a stern look. I shook my head and bit the inside of my cheek to hold back my annoyance at her, but I couldn't just stand there saying nothing.

"I don't leave anyone behind."

-

My mind drifts in and out of consciousness, but my old words still swim to the front of my brain.

'I don't leave anyone behind.'
I sit up all of a sudden, a hot wave of adrenaline coursing through my veins and into my legs that I throw onto the floor next to the bed, standing up and panting for breaths. What were we thinking? There shouldn't be time to rest when Catra and Adora could be in there being tortured, yet here we are, lying in bed like there's nothing wrong.

I'm tempted to wake Rogelio, but I know he'll only try to stop me, so instead I grab my staff and sneak out of our bedroom and into the living room. I quietly pull on an old pair of shoes that I left by the door and gently creep outside. I lock the door with our rusty key and take in a breath of crisp night air, allowing it to fill my lungs and fuel my system.

I can't see the ship from this side of the hill, but after I hike my way up I can see it clear as day, it's silver exterior reflecting the moonlight and shimmering like waves under the sun. The crunches of dirt beneath my feet threaten to tell everything inside the ship i'm here, but it doesn't matter. I'm done waiting around, and I don't leave anyone behind.

I need to help out somehow, so i'm going to try and scout out the security patterns. What good will going into the vents do if there are traps lurking around?

I want to concentrate on the door of the ship, but my mind feels... foggy. What's wrong with me?

I notice one of the slender glass people from before standing just a couple of metres away, so I crouch behind a dry bush where I can catch a clear shot of what's going on. It paces forward a little and turns it's head left and right like it's surveying the ground before placing it's hand on some kind of scanner on the wall next to the door. The scanner glows and the door shudders open, creaking and groaning as it rises to let the guard in.

After the crystal man enters the ship, the door starts to shut again, and I only have one mission on my mind-

Follow it inside, check out their security system, and pass the information on to the princesses.

Because I'm done being the Kyle who messes everything up.

(On wattpad chapter 11 was in two parts but I’m combining them here)

Kyle's POV

I sneak behind the person of crystal with fast and quiet breaths down the corridor of the ship, my staff readied before me in case it turns around.

With every step I take further away from where I came in, the clearer my mind becomes and the more I regret what I did. I want to turn back, I want to agree with Ro and the others, but I also want to make sure we're prepared, and I also want to feel useful without any help from anybody else for once.

When my grip on my staff tightens, I get an old but familiar flashback.

-

My grip tightened on my staff and I try not to go numb with the cold. Snow piled up around us and the weak signal made our communicators break up slightly, but Catra's voice rang out loud and clear.

"What are you waiting for? Burn it!"

I looked to my left and frowned at Lonnie, who stared back for a split second before shrugging.

"Let's do it."

She said. I looked to my right then, to see if Rogelio was on board, but he was looking at his feet with his usual stern expression. Lonnie lit up the block of wood in her hand and raised her arm to throw it, but I grabbed her arm and yanked her back. A small piece of my hair was singed away from the flames and I could feel it's heat painting my skin. Lonnie pushed me away and shot me a glare.

"Kyle! Back off!"
She exclaimed, flinging the block of fire into the small village before us. I could feel the contents of my stomach rising up my throat with guilt. Red and orange flames began to spring up from the thatched roofs of the tiny houses, licking the frost-bitten air and spreading from wall to wall, home to home. I was hoping that because the straw was damp with snow the flames would be put out, but I was far from right.

"Why did you do that? There are innocent people in there!"
I shouted, trying to get out of Rogelio's arms as he pushed me away. Lonnie strode ahead with a scowl on her face.

"We're soldiers. That's what we do."

-

I shake myself out of the memory by gripping my hair tight enough to feel a pinch, a small pinch that reels me back in and convinces me to keep going.

I try not to think about the past, but it's not much use when they visions force their way into my mind anyways. Every time I followed orders while I was a soldier, somebody got seriously hurt. I didn't have a say, then. If I didn't do what they told me to...

Now is different. I know that Glimmer wants us to follow the map to save Catra and Adora, but there's no way I can sleep knowing I'm this close to them without getting a head start on the obstacles we'll have to avoid. When I get out of here, they'll wonder why they never sent me in in the first place.

The strange man of glass stops walking all of a sudden and I'm shocked back into paying attention, halting immediately and praying that it can't hear me breathing. I want to run, but if I do it'll definitely see me.

It starts to turn slowly, not slow enough for me to make a run for it, but not quick enough for it to see me yet. I stand and hold my breath. Crap. I should have just waited until-

Suddenly I'm thrown around the corner out of it's view and slammed to the ground, before sliding across the floor with something on top of me. No, not something.

Someone.

"Rogelio? How-"
Rogelio puts his hand over my mouth and I close my eyes out of relief. Despite how heavy he feels on top of me, It's the safest and most comfortable I've felt all night. I can hear the footsteps of the crystal guard getting further away again, and sigh when Rogelio lifts his hand and rolls onto the floor.

I open my mouth to say something, but he holds up a finger and stands up. He looks mad. Really mad.

I stand up and hug myself, not knowing what else to do, letting my staff shake in my trembling hand. Rogelio walks ahead and signals for me to follow him, so I do so with a horrible sinking feeling in my stomach.

"Ro-"
He shakes his head and points over at a guard that's rounding the corner opposite us. We press ourselves against the wall and I hold my breath until it passes.

'Why did you come here?'
Rogelio asks, his eyes still trained on the corridor. He pulls me by the hand down the narrow hallway I just followed the first guard through.

"I wanted to help."
I hiss. He frowns and pushes me back against the wall to hide from another guard.

'We were going to help, tomorrow.'
He replies. I shake my head and follow him again.

"There could be traps in the vents."
Rogelio turns to me with an almost puzzled look.

'Why would there be traps in the vents?'
This question makes me want to rethink why I came in here in the first place, but there's no time. We make our way back to the doors and I get the sudden impulse to run away, but Rogelio already has my arm in his gentle grasp, ready to pull me outside with him.

We run to the bushes opposite us and I fall into them, spreading out my arms and letting out shaky breaths. Ro crouches next to me, but he doesn't smile.

'That was really stupid.'
He says, shaking his head. A pang of guilt hits me.

"I was trying to be helpful!"
I whisper.

'We had orders. Following them is helpful.'
He says back, but quieter. I frown at him and then squint at the ship door for any guards. Only one walks in after following the same route as the one I followed. Rogelio runs discretely to the other side of the hill where we can't be seen and I run after him with a scowl on my face.

"We can't just sit around and do nothing!"
I whisper-shout, trying to catch up with him as he gets further to the bottom. He stops in his tracks and turns to look glare at me. I've never seen him look at me this way, but it's certainly not a nice feeling.

'You could have been caught. You would have been, if I didn't catch you first!'
He argues, folding his arms. I roll my eyes and lean on my staff for some kind of support. A new kind of anger fills me, one that I've never felt for Rogelio before. It feels like I'm offended, but also guilty...

"We're going to get caught if we go through the vents!"
Rogelio groans a little before he replies.

'No, we're not. Why don't you trust the mission?'
Rogelio's POV

I shake my head and wait with an annoyed expression for his response. Does he even understand how dangerous what he just did was?

"I do trust it, I just don't trust her!"
He exclaims, pointing his finger in the direction of the ship. A twisted feeling of anger and worry runs through me and I have to turn around and walk to stop myself from saying something I'll regret.

Sometimes I forget that he has a lot going on in his head, and that he often doesn't have control over what he does. I'm really hoping that's why he went to that ship, because if he knew what he was doing I could get even more annoyed, and that won't end well for us or our relationship for the next while, at least.

I care about him so much, but sometimes I think it could be too much.

'You could have asked Glimmer about checking the ship out before you snook out on your own.'
I grumble. The sound of crunchy plants and sand gets a bit louder behind me so I know he's right there, but I don't want to look at him right now.

"They would have said no."
He whispers. I frown and squeeze my hands into tight fists to contain my annoyance.

'Then why did you do it?'
I turn for an answer this time, but he looks as angry as I feel. His eyes are glassy and his cheeks look red, although it's hard to tell in the night. He glares at me and folds his arms again.

"I told you, I wanted to be helpful!"
He looks doubtful of his own answer for a second, but soon enough he resorts back to glaring again.

'It was so dangerous! You could have at least woken me up!'
I growl, a bit louder this time then before. Kyle scoffs and walks faster towards home.

"Nobody ever thinks I can do things on my own, do they? It's always Rogelio to the rescue!"
He says, his voice wavering slightly as though he's crying. I want to ask if he's okay, but then I remember how wreckless he was and continue marching back to our flat.

'Not everything is about you.'
I mumble. Part of me regrets it, but the other part desperately

wants him to hear me. He looks over his shoulder with slits for eyes and my heart sinks to my feet in seconds.

"I know. Nothing is about me."
And with that, he storms ahead. I kick a stone out of frustration and watch as he makes his way down the dark street with his staff dragging behind him and his head bowed low.

I don't think I've ever been this mad at him before.

# Twelve

Chapter Notes

Bit of a update spam tonight, lol!

Adora's POV (special)

When I wake up my eyes feel stingy and raw. The light in our 'cell' never gets turned off, so we don't get a break in the dark. I watch as tiny dust particles float in front of my face and smile when Catra wakes up on the bed a few feet from mine. She yawns and reaches her hand out to me, which I take into my own.

"Maybe they'll come for us today?
She asks. I nod and squint over at the wall. The cell is all white, with a glossy floor and shiny walls. The door is built in somewhere, and you can only open it from the other side, so there's no point in trying to escape. We've tried to climb up to the vents, but they're way to high up to get to.

Our beds are small and only a couple of feet apart, but it feels like we're ages away when we're sleeping. Catra can't even curl up with me anymore, because I can barely fit alone.

"I thought I heard growling or something last night, but I think I just imagined it."
I say, stretching out my arms and lifting my legs out onto the floor. Catra groans and folds her arms.

"You sure you can't summon She-Ra or something?"
She mumbles. I shake my head and rub my eyes.

"I don't think magic works in here. Otherwise, Glimmer would have teleported in already."
Catra opens her mouth but instead of her voice a loud clanking sound comes from the wall. The slab of door hidden into it slides open and the woman from before waltzes in, her heels clicking

against the floor as she makes her way over to us. I glare at her but she just smiles.

"Adora, it's about time I show you something."
She says, smiling as though she just gave me a present. I frown over at Catra, who's already shooting her a death stare. I stand up and nod, following her out of the cell and into the dark corridor. The crystals that were glowing the first time we came here are dark now, and it's no longer as welcoming as we were first led to believe.

"Your sword looks beautiful up on my wall, don't you think?"
The woman says as we enter the hall, and points up at the sword mounted above where we first spoke. I look to my feet again and continue to follow her.

"Aren't you going to tell me your name?"
I ask. She stops walking and brushes a piece of snow white hair from her face before smiling at me again.

"I'm Astra. Of course, you don't know me. I'm from Latura."
She says. Her voice is smooth, like water rippling over stones, so I can't tell if she's lying or not.

"Latura?"
I say. She sighs and wraps an arm around my shoulders. I tense up where she's touching me and try to regulate my breathing so she doesn't notice.

"I live in this ship, on another planet, usually. I used to live with the first ones, before that place was all blown to bits."
I shake my head and push myself away from her.

"What? What do you mean, blown to bits?"
She frowns at me and steers me over to the sword.

"There were two planets. One of them, I was from. Most of the first ones escaped to the second, however. Etheria. That's where we are now, correct?"
I don't answer, so she continues.

"But then Etheria was... gone. It disappeared, and nobody knew where it went. Of course, my planet was still there, and Horde Prime thought it was necessary to blow it up for good measure."
The lump in my throat rises up when she says this. Her planet... destroyed?

"I'm... I'm sorry that your planet was destroyed. But why do you need me?"
She looks down at me and sighs.

"Because with you, with She-Ra, my people will be safe. Most of them vacated to another planet, Latura, but we don't have any magic, or technology, other than this place. With you... we could build an empire."
Beads of sweat gather on my forehead and under my arms, but I maintain a sturdy stance. Astra runs a finger over the grooves and edges of my sword before turning to face me with the biggest, most fake grin I've ever seen.

"Oh, I forgot to mention it before, but two of your friends were caught snooping around last night in my cameras. If they're caught in here again- they'll be taken to Latura as my prisoners."
I shake my head and try to think of who it could have been. Was the growling I heard last night Rogelio?

"Wait! Why won't you just fly us over there now? Why wait here?"
Astra shrugs and places a cold hand on my cheek.

"Because when the princesses come to save you, I'll capture them, too. I need all the magic I can get."
Her voice echoes around the hall, but I shut it out as best I can.

Hopefully the princesses know better than to come in here.

# Thirteen

Kyle's POV

Nobody knows about last night except me and Rogelio. I don't want anybody to know, and Rogelio couldn't tell anybody even if he wanted to. If the others can feel the tension between us, they don't say anything. We're too busy trying to plan how we're going to save Catra and Adora.

"Okay, so this is the route that Scorpia and Bow are going to take, and this is the way that Kyle and Rogelio will go."
Glimmer explains, running her finger along the map of the vents, tracing over thick and blindingly clear routes drawn in sparkles.
The four of us nod. I can taste blood coming from my lip because i'm chewing it so much, and my shirt is crumpled in my fist beneath the table, but I don't let Rogelio see. Not until he at least tries to listen to my explanation. I'm not sure how i'm going to get through tonight in a tiny vent with him, alone.

"What are we supposed to do when we get in there?"
Bow asks,gulping at the blueprints.

"If you follow the directions mapped out-"
Perfuma starts.

"It should leave you in the room where Catra and Adora are being held. You have to go in opposite directions in case... in case there's any setbacks."
Mermista frowns at the table.

"So... they just bring them back through the vents the way they came?"
I want to block out the conversation to calm down, but unfortunately since i'm a key part to the mission I have no choice but to listen. Scorpia nods at Mermista and pats me on the back lightly.

"We can do this."

(Time Skip- evening)

"Second left, third right, left-"
I mumble, resting my head on my knees with the list of directions clutched in my hands. I'm sitting on the floor of a guest room in the palace, with my back resting against the bedframe behind me. Rogelio is on the other side doing the same.

The more I look at the sheet of paper the more blurred the words and arrows become. Letters swirl into meaningless symbols and arrows flip so that they don't make sense anymore.

I turn a little to look over the bed. I can see the back of Rogelio's head, bowed down, obviously trying to learn off our route to follow in the vents.

"Can you please just let me talk?"
I ask. My voice sounds out of place after all the silence. He turns to me with a frown before turning back to his paper.

"I just wanna tell you what happened! It was all so blurry-"
He turns to me again with an even bigger frown so I stop talking and try to read the paper again. Second left, third right, left... I'm useless at this.

"What if something goes wrong and we can't save them?"
I ask. I'm not expecting an answer, but Rogelio responds.

'If we follow the instructions, we will.'
Maybe this was a dig at me, but I'm just glad he actually tried to communicate. I rest my head back against the bed and close my eyes in an attempt to memorise the words a little better, but nothing helps.

"I didn't know what I was doing until I was in the ship."
I mumble, my eyes still closed. I know he won't answer, but at least he can hear me.

"Once I was in there, the only way I wouldn't get caught was to follow the guard. I knew there were more coming behind me."
I hear him moving a little but he doesn't try to say anything, so I sigh and hold the directions in front of me again.

Third left, second right- No, that's not it. Second left, third right-

Somebody knocks on the door and Rogelio opens it almost immediately, obviously desperate to get away from the tension. Bow stands at the door with both of our staffs in his arms.

"Hey guys, I hope you don't mind Glimmer getting these, you sort of need them."
I smile and take one from him. Rogelio does the same.

"Thanks, and it's no problem."
I say quietly.

"We're going to meet up outside in ten minutes."
Bow says, and jogs down the corridor. I turn to Ro and begin to say something, but then realise that I've said enough, and he's probably sick of hearing my voice now. So I stay quiet.

Instead, we silently walk down the long and empty hallways to the garden, ready to begin our mission.

Our mission to rescue Catra and Adora.

# Fourteen

Kyle's POV

I've been scared plenty of times in my life, but I've only ever been terrified twice. Once, when Bow appeared as a hologram in the sky and literally hundreds of Hordak clones started to surround us, and the other time being when I had a nightmare and thought that Rogelio had died in real life, not realising it was a twisted dream.

It's a sinking feeling in your stomach, one that finds its way around your body and settles there, eventually getting to your head and forcing you to overthink all of the horrible things that could happen.

That's how I feel now as I slide down into the hole in the ship roof, landing on my hands and knees behind Rogelio in a hot silver vent. He looks over his shoulder to check that I got in through his night vision visor that he kept from our cadet days, and starts to crawl almost immediately, not wasting any time on me.

I follow him and count my breaths to calm myself down. One... We pass by a passageway that looks identical to the one we're crawling through, only shorter. Two... I accidentally grab Rogelio's tail but he doesn't say anything. Three... we stop crawling.

"What's wrong?"
I ask, not sure if I'm even getting a reply. Rogelio starts up again and nods towards another passageway, which he turns in to. I follow him and wish that we were a little quieter rather than clanging and smacking off the walls of the vent with even the slightest of movements.

I try to listen for Scorpia and Bow, but since they're at the opposite end of the ship to us it sounds like we're on our own. Maybe we'll meet in the middle.

What I can hear is faint clicking, from what can only be one of those glass people patrolling the corridors underneath us. Images of their creepy blank faces fill my mind.

"Hey, Ro? You know where we're going, right?"
I hiss. Rogelio nods and I sigh. Why is this so awkward? I know why, obviously, but it still feels unfamiliar. We take another turn and I almost crash into him, but thankfully I steady myself before that can happen.

The air in the vent is so hot that when I breathe it in it feels almost damp and heavy, like it's clogging my throat and slowing my breaths down. I'm too preoccupied to fight off the flashback.

-

I was at home, in bed, but nobody was there with me. It was hot yet I had a cold from visiting Frosta's kingdom, so my nose was blocked and I could hardly speak. I could barely inhale for over one second and my chest felt like somebody was pressing down on it, limiting me.

Rogelio came in and sat on the edge of the bed beside my legs and told me to try and relax, to count my breaths and notice my surroundings, so I did.

I started to count in my head, and I looked out the window to the busy street. Then I looked over to our shoes lined up on the floor, and smiled at how much smaller mine were than his.

"Thank you."

-

I focus on Rogelio's tail and try to count as many scales as I can as a distraction, but they all blur up until I can only see a green blob.

"Are we-"
He lifts a finger for me to stop talking so I bite the inside of my

cheek in annoyance, not noticing that he had stopped crawling and smacking into him.

I open my mouth to say something, but Rogelio lifts his tail to cover my mouth without even having to look.

'This is it. This is the room.'
He grumbles. I raise my eyebrows, grateful that I didn't speak, as he starts to unbolt the silver grate before us, loosening it and pushing it open as silently as he can. He jumps down and I presume he lands on his feet, but I can't tell with the dark.

I can't see a thing below the grate except a full blackness that fills the room. I falter at the gate before taking a deep breath and sliding my legs out of the square shaped hole.

For Catra and Adora.

I jump out and feel sick when the drop lasts much longer than expected, making the fall much more nerve-wracking. I brace myself for impact with the floor but gasp when I'm caught in Rogelio's arms. I clutch into his shirt for a second but let go when I remember our current situation, now feeling embarrassed and awkward when I scramble from his grasp.

"Are they in here?"
I whisper. I hear Rogelio taking a few steps and hold my breath until he answers.

'No...'
My muscles tense up as if on cue.

"What? But the map said-"
He nudges me and directs my focus up to the opposite wall, where the other vent is open, too.

"Scorpia and Bow..."
All of a sudden the light turns on, a bright and blinding white light that makes it feel like my eyes have been set on fire.

I start to hyperventilate with out any time to react differently. Because my eyes don't have any time to adjust to the light they go blurry and all I can do is take hold of Rogelio's hand. Fighting with me or not, he squeezes my fingers and pulls me closer to his side.

I squint up to the ceiling to try and find the source of the light but there's nothing. When I turn back to eye-level, however, I feel a shock of dread coursing through me.

"Hello, boys!"
The woman from the dance stands in the doorway, leaning against the doorframe with one hand on her hip. Her soft blue skin is illuminated under the light and her snowy hair glitters and shines as she smiles at us.

Rogelio pulls his staff from the holster on his back and runs for her, quicker than I have time to think, but she grabs it from the air and pulls it from him with a sick and twisted grin.

"I don't think so."
She says. Her voice rings through the whole room before bouncing into our ears. Rogelio slowly walks backwards towards me, but my eyes don't move from the woman's face.

"Once I saw that you two were crawling through my vents, and that your friends had stolen my guests, I guessed you were on your way here."
She says. She walks a little closer to us and we take a step back, like we're magnets pushing against each other at matching ends.

I frown at her, despite how scared I am, and ball my hands into fists.

"Where are they? What did you do with them?"
I ask. The woman laughs and folds her arms.

"They got out, silly. But it doesn't matter, does it? Because Adora will come back for you eventually."
I'm not sure if I want her to or not.

Rogelio lifts his arm to take the other staff from behind him but jumps when a crystal person takes it before he can, handing it over to the blue woman.

"Who are you? Why-"
She cuts off my questions with a cold stare. The smell of hot metal fills my nose and I turn to where the vents were open, only to see that one of her crystal assistants has weld them shut. Rogelio glances at me with fear in his eyes and we have no choice but to listen to the woman's manic laughter.

"You two look so scared! I'm a friend."
She says, before the shiny white door of the cell slides shut in front of her, and locks the both of us and our anxiety inside.

Catra's POV

We clamber out of the vent and find ourselves in the roof of the ship. I pull Adora out with me and we suck in breaths of the fresh air with teary eyes. I never thought I'd feel so happy to be outside.

Adora wraps her arms around Bow and Scorpia's necks and I wiggle my way in too, not caring about judgement right now.

"We didn't know you were going to save us!"
Adora says, her voice muffled from her head being buried in Bow's shoulder. I nod and break away from the hug, but my smile slowly fades when I notice Scorpia staring at the opposite end of the roof.

"Scorpia?"
I ask, trying my best to be gentle. She smiles at me.

"Oh, uh... it's just... Rogelio and Kyle came too. You know, just in case one of our routes was booby-trapped."
Her voice is soft but shaky. Bow frowns at her and scratches the back of his neck nervously. I can feel my ears twitching with worry. Are they trapped somehow? Adora gives me a nervous look which only makes it feel worse.

"Maybe they went for the sword?"
She asks. She sounds hopeful, but even then it sounds like a dangerous thing to do. Bow shakes his head.

"No. We specifically said that we would get the sword another time. And besides, shouldn't Adora be able to conjure it or something?"
We all turn to Adora and she sticks her arm out with a look of heavy concentration, before lowering it again with a frown.

"The magic is still too strong in there."
I take her hand and squeeze it to ease her frustration.

"I told Glimmer to meet us- ARGH!"
We all jump when Glimmer appears next to us with a huge grin. She grabs me and Adora and kisses us both on the cheek for what feels like hours until she eventually backs off. I want to be annoyed, but I have to admit it- I'm happy to see her too.

Our smiles drop once more when Scorpia looks off into the distance again.

"Ro and Kyle are still in there. I don't think they're coming out any time soon."
She says. Glimmer covers her mouth and begins to page back and forth.

"Okay, we'll wait a couple more minutes. If they don't come out..."
I finish her sentence.

"It's another rescue mission."
The others nod and start to wait when I spot a silhouette at the other end of the roof. I nod in its direction to show the others and they look, too.

"Is it Kyle?"
Scorpia asks. Adora shakes her head and squints.

"It looks more like Rogelio..."
Her eyes widen in an instant and all of a sudden Glimmer has

teleported us to Bright Moon. I push her off me and frown at her.

"What was that? What about Kyle and Rogelio?"
I exclaim, waving my arms around like a lunatic. Adora shakes her head and lowers my arms for me.

"It was one of those crystal people. It was pointing something at us, Catra."
I brush her off and shake my head.

"Come on, we could have easily fought it off!"
Bow sighs and pulls his arrow holster from his back.

"It took a lot of planning to find a way to rescue you two. Them things are too dangerous to fight on our own."
He says. I frown at him and fold my arms.

"Fine."
Glimmer shakes her head and grabs her hair out of what looks to be stress.

"No, it's not fine. They took Kyle and Rogelio! That's not fine! I sent them in there-"
Bow wraps his arms around her shoulders and steers her down the corridor, beckoning for us to follow too.

When we enter the room full of our other friends they rush over to greet us immediately, but the time for smiles and laughter doesn't last long.

"Time for more planning."
Bow says, sitting at the large round table. Perfuma and Mermista share a worried look.

"They got Rogelio and Kyle."

# Fifteen

Rogelio's POV

I wobble a little under Kyle's weight when he stands up on my shoulders, and hold his feet as I stand up. We've been in this cell for a couple of hours now, and this feels like our one hundredth attempt to open the hatch into the vent, but something feels wrong about giving up.

"I just need to- GAH!"
Kyle slips and I catch him with ease.

"Thanks..."
I set him down as quick as I caught him and turn to sit on one of the tiny beds. The cell is warm, not warm enough to make us sweat, but not cold enough to make us shiver. It's really hard to be mad at Kyle right now, but what if he's the reason we're trapped here? What if she saw us somehow last night, and knew from there we were coming?

"Rogelio, can you let me talk?"
I turn to him and shrug. It's not like there's anything else to do. He sits in front of me on the other bed and runs his hands through his hair. He only does that when he's really anxious.

"Look, I-I'm sorry. I think it was a panic attack, but I'm not going to blame that for what I did."
I look up from my hands for a second and find that his own hands are trembling on his lap. Am I really going to stay mad at him? The one person I love the most in this world?

I reach out and take his hands into mine to try and help his breathing. He smiles and closes his eyes to continue.

"I just... I got so sick of following orders. My whole life, our whole life, we never got a say. I thought I could help by scouting out the security patterns or something."

A tear falls down his cheek and I feel like something is tugging in my stomach.

"I can tell now that it was a stupid plan."
He laughs through his tears and so do I, the knot in my stomach slowly unraveling as I squeeze his hands a little tighter. Now isn't the time to be fighting with him.

"I'm really scared, Rogelio."
He mumbles. I nod and pull him to me, from there he sits on my lap and wraps his arms around my shoulders. His face fits perfectly into the crook of my neck, allowing his tears to pool at my collarbone and slowly trickle back down my chest, but I don't mind. He has too much hurt to focus on right now.

'I'm sorry I got so mad. I was just worried.'
I growl. Hopefully he can understand me through how upset he is. He pulls his head back and looks down into my eyes before smiling.

"I love you."

He says. I push a stray chunk of hair behind his ear and nod.

'I love you too.'
Sometimes a moment can last a lifetime. This is one of those moments. He's taller than usual, sitting on my lap, so he can look down into my eyes the way I would usually do it. His legs are digging into the bed either side of me, but his arms are draped gently on my shoulders, lightly and with care. I forget that I'm in a cell. I forget that we're being kept as prisoners. I forget that we're in potential danger.

But he makes it worth it.

I'm usually the one to protect Kyle. I'm usually the one who makes sure no harm comes to him in any way, yet now, holding his lower back as he smiles down at me, I feel the safest I've ever felt, like Kyle himself is warding off any harm, any danger. He's making me feel this way, and I love him for it.

"Why are you looking at me that way?"
He says, a small airy laugh escaping his lips after he says it. I shrug and smile at him, my heart starting to thump at an alarming rate. He always radiates this heat, a welcoming aura, but right now it's even more than that.

I really wish we were at home right now.

"For once I'm on top!"
Kyle says. We both go wide eyed for a moment before bursting into a fit of hysterical laughter. I fall backwards and he rolls over next to me, still laughing but his face gone crimson.

"Somebody will save us. Remember when they were only eighteen? They won a war!"
He says, shifting the mood but still laying close by my side, his body pressing against mine as though he's fearful I'll slip away. I nod and try not to let our surroundings make me uncomfortable.

'I hope they come soon.'
I grumble. Kyle turns to look at me and lifts his hand to caress the side of my face. His skin is cold, but not as cold as it usually is. It's calming.

"Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."
I smile at him and pull him closer, holding him in a tight but gentle embrace.

We have each other.

# 16 (sorry for taking so long!)

Kyle's POV

My back aches when I wake up, but not as much as my head does, the intense white light of the cell having never dimmed since we got trapped in here. I sit up and pat the two thick blankets I'm on, satisfied that they kept me warm at least.

Rogelio is on the floor next to me, curled up on both of the mattresses from our beds which he just about fits on. The bed frames themselves stand idle and empty, all of their metal bars and wires exposed.

I slowly slide my legs back so that my knees are in contact with my nose, and sink my fingers into my messy hair. My stomach growls in reminder that we haven't eaten in hours.

I'm not usually one for eating a lot, I forget to most of the time. If it weren't for Rogelio reminding me to get some meals into me everyday, I'd probably have starved ages ago.

'One, two, three...'
I recite numbers in my mind, hoping it will help with the anxiety, but it doesn't. Rogelio's arm slides across the floor and his hand is left resting on my foot, sending me into an old, forgotten memory.

-

I sat on the bench in the locker room, my leg stretched out before me. Rogelio was holding my foot, slowly rotating it to exersise my ankle and pushing it back to stretch the muscle I had pulled. Lonnie sat next to me and have me a nudge.

"You'd wanna toughen up, Rogelio won't always be there when you fall."
She snapped, obviously still upset from her argument with Catra. I rolled my eyes but Rogelio snickered a little as he pushed my foot

back some more. When Lonnie stomped off to finish her argument, he slid over to me and pecked my cheek.

We were only twelve at the time, and I didn't know what love was. I didn't know that our bond was going to be irreversible since then, but I'm glad it was.

-

I force my eyes to open and loosen my unconscious grip on my hair. I know we've tried to get out a countless amount of times, and that that creepy lady is probably watching my every move, but either way I look up at the sealed off vent grates, their silver edges molten and fused into the wall. Some rustling next to me tells me Rogelio is awake so I turn back to him.

'Good morning.'
He grumbles. I smile at him and bend over to leave a small kiss on his forehead.

"Good morning."
I can see a fuzzy outline of everything in the cell reflected on the glossy wall opposite us, but I can't quite remember where the door begins or ends. Rogelio sits upright and looks at the wall too, obviously thinking about something similar.

"Is she gonna feed us?"
I ask, cradling my stomach. Rogelio shrugs and glares at where the door should probably be.

The woman with blue skin and white hair hasn't bothered us since yesterday, and I haven't even heard a single footstep since then, either. In the beginning I thought she was going to let us starve, but then I realised that she probably wants to use us as some kind of bribe.

But even then, the others don't know if we're alive...

'Stop worrying!'
Rogelio growls. I smile at him and let out a sigh.

"Why haven't I thought of that?"
I say. He opens his mouth but instead of his voice I hear a click coming from the wall. There's a couple of hissing noises before a slab of door slides open, and the woman who captured us stands smiling at us behind it.

"Good morning dears!"
She sings. I scrunch up my nose when she uses this pet name, but my expression soon shifts when I see the tray she's carrying.

There's four slices of bread on the tray, with a brown paste slathered on top of them, along with two glasses of what must be water. She sets the tray between us both and clops off almost instantly.

She pauses at the door and swivels to the empty bedframes, her eyes shaped like slits.

"I like what you've done with the place."
And with that, she leaves.

For a second I feel energy rushing through me, making me wish I could just run at her here and now and knock her to the ground, but a part of me knows I'm too weak.

Rogelio frowns at where she was standing, obviously confused, but I'm not really paying attention. All I can focus on is the food.

Without thinking I grab a slice of bread and lift it to my mouth, but Rogelio grabs my arm and stops me just as it meets my bottom lip.

'Careful?'
He growls. I groan and he picks up a slice, too.

"I think it's chocolate."
I say. I sound annoyed, but I'm only agitated by my hunger. Rogelio nods and we bite into the bread at the same time.

Chocolate.

Within minutes all of the food and water is gone, and nothing remains on the tray but crumbs and tiny water droplets that drip from the glasses. Ro smiles at me.

'We got fed.'
I nod and trail my finger around the tray for no reason in particular. Rogelio reaches over and uses his thumb to wipe a smidge of chocolate from my nose and I blush a little. It feels like old times.

Is it bad that I'm finding this slightly peaceful?

"It's probably gonna take them a while to save us. It took us ages, and we only had to map a route in the vents."
I say. Rogelio nods and squeezes my hand with a smile as a reminder that he's here with me.

"I still feel like this is my fault."
I grumble. He shakes his head and moves the tray so I can scoot over to him, and he wraps an arm around me so that were hugging sideways.

'It's not your fault.'
He growls.

'Nothing was ever your fault.'

# 17

Chapter Notes

> guys sorry this story is taking so long to post. I wrote it 2 years ago and It’s shockingly bad in my eyes because i think I’ve improved in my writing. I’m gonna post it so you can all get an ending, but I know it’s not the best!!!

Kyle's POV

It wasn't long before my stomach start growling again. The thought of her never feeding us again played around my head until I had no choice but to sing to distract myself. I haven't sang since my Horde days, and I only did it then when my day was really bad.

Catra or Lonnie would usually tell me to be quiet if I was too loud, so it felt strange letting the soft song escape my lips without somebody getting annoyed.

Rogelio actually complimented me on it, which made me feel a bit better. But now I'm just lying on the floor with my feet up on the wall, begging for something interesting to happen.

'Why did you stop singing?'

Rogelio asks. I turn my head so that I'm looking up at him.

"I can't think of anything else to sing."

I grumble. He nods and looks away as if to think about it, and then looks back to me with a smile.

'What about...'

I can't catch the last few words.

"I didn't catch that, sorry."

I say guiltily. He nods and taps out a beat on the bedframe next to him.

"Oh! Our song!"

I sit up and he smiles at me.

There's a song that we used to sing, well, I used to sing, in the Horde. It was usually when the both of us were stationed together somewhere on our own, and we had nothing to do but wait it out.

I close my eyes and let the words flow out, hoping that I don't sound like some kind of dying bird.

"When we're out
Doing our jobs,
I feel empty.

But when you're there
I can feel it,
Something risky.

If they knew
About us,
Would they care?

Would we be gone
Kicked from the Horde,
Banned from there?"

I stop my singing and open my eyes slowly, not realising there's tears filling them. I think there's more lyrics, but I can't bring myself to utter them. The pain that used to own us when I made that song up was something unimaginable now, and it feels weird to let it resurface.

Rogelio is smiling at me, which makes my cheeks flare up.

"It wasn't that bad, right?"

He laughs a little and shakes his head. After a couple of seconds my stomach starts to churn again.

"I wonder if she heard me, on cameras or something."

I say, biting my bottom lip. Rogelio shrugs and opens his arms to me, so I naturally crawl over and let him hold me.

'She's lucky if she did.'

He growls. I smile and stare at the wall where she came through earlier, and almost like magic, the door starts to slide open to reveal a crystal person standing there, it's glowing eyes conveying little to no emotion. Rogelio stiffens and I move closer to him.

"Please, follow me!"

It sings. The voice is that woman's, but it sounds muffled and strange. Rogelio and I share a look before standing up to follow it. What other choice do we have?

Stepping out into the corridor feels almost illegal, the pink and orange lights on the walls seem too bright and happy to belong here and the extra guard behind us making sure we don't try to run doesn't feel like much of a threat.

Without saying a word my fingers interlock with Rogelio's and we follow the guard, or whatever it's supposed to be, hand in hand. It's glass feet make tiny clicking sounds against the smooth white floor as we walk through different hallways and doorways, eventually leading us into the giant hall we first visited for the 'dance'.

There's a long table in the centre of it now, however, full of hot food and colourful sweets and lined with over a dozen chairs, as if they were supposed to be filled. I look up at Rogelio in disbelief and he frowns at me, obviously confused.

The clicking of heels announces the arrival of the blue skinned woman, who sashays from the double doors opposite us and

waves an arm adorned with jewelry towards the large table.

"Oh, don't be shy! Sit, sit!"

Her voice is shrill and almost painful to listen to. Rogelio and I sit at one end, opposite each other and as far away from her as possible. She sits a couple of seats down and smiles at us.

Under the table, our feet are linked together like we used to link them in meetings or classes. A glass waiter sets an empty plate before us all and I get an uneasy feeling in my stomach. She's being too nice.

"My name is Astra. I know the strapping young man with blonde hair is Kyle, correct? But what about you?"

My insides squirm when she makes this comment, but I try my best not to be rude.

"His name's Rogelio."

I mumble. She hears me and smiles.

"Kyle and Rogelio. What lovely names."

I look over her head and see she-ra's sword mounted on the wall. She catches me and laughs.

"Oh, that old thing? That's mine."

I open my mouth to argue but Rogelio gives me a small kick under the table so I shut up and glare at him. Astra starts filling her plate.

"Eat up! You must be starving."

She says, no longer looking at us. Rogelio and I share a look, but there's nothing much to discuss. We're starving and weak, and there's plates full of hot food ready for us, so why shouldn't we eat it? Astra seems to be eating it, so surely it isn't laced, right?

My anxiety bounces around my brain and my breaths quicken but I load my plate and start to eat silently.

"I have to say, I admire your relationship."

Astra says, still focusing on her food. I look to Rogelio and we both frown. Astra continues to speak.

"Like brothers!"

I snort halfway through a spoon of mashed potatoes and wince when the stuff gets wedged in my throat, the burning nearly as bad as Rogelio being referred to as my brother. Rogelio himself is glancing at her with an embarrassed expression, Astra simply smiling at us.

"I've never thought of it like that... ever..."

I mumble. Rogelio smirks and the lady at the other end of the table nods.

"Ah, so it's not brotherly love then?"

Why is this woman so nosy? My face must be as red as a tomato but it doesn't make a difference since she's still looking at her plate. Rogelio is holding in laughter with every mouthful.

Despite the awkward conversation, the meal is delicious. Much nicer than our usual carrot and potato stew back home, and much more filling, too. After eating it all I'm sort of confused as to why she didn't give us bread again. Is she trying to win our trust?

"I'm terribly sorry we didn't have a meal like this sooner. I was just so busy trying to contact my family back home that I forgot."

Astra says. Her voice echoes like song around the hall. Family? Home?

"It's okay."

I say quietly. It would be great if she could just let us go, but I don't see that happening anytime soon. At least not until the others show up.
Rogelio wriggles his feet in closer to mine and I give him a reassuring pat with the toe of my shoe.

Astra stands up and walks over to the huge double doors where she first took Catra and Adora.

"Well, aren't you going to follow me? I suppose you would like to know why I'm here."

# 18

Chapter Summary

the cringe is real

We follow Astra down another series of corridors before reaching a small white door adorned with orange crystals. She pushes it open and beckons us inside, so we follow her.

The ceiling is high above our heads and the walls look like they could fall on top of us at any stage, but what's hanging on them is more fascinating than the architecture.

There are weapons of all kinds on the wall, and they feel almost threatening to look at. Silver axes, golden chains and even swords made from crystals have all been mounted up, their surfaces glistening under the intense light.

"Magnificent, aren't they?"

Astra whispers, running her finger over the blade of a shiny purple arrow. I feel a sudden shooting pain in my temple, but I let it go. The light on this place is so harsh that it must be getting to my head.

Kyle hugs himself and looks around at the arms surrounding us with wary eyes.

"What has all this got to do with why you're here?"

He asks, gulping. Astra sighs and places her hands on her hips.

"Nothing, really."

I look down to Kyle with a frown and we share a confused look. Another sharp pain courses through my head but I ignore it.

"So then why are we here?"

Kyle asks, his voice laced with worry. Astra chuckles and checks her teeth in the reflection of a blade, before turning back to us and sighing. She looks into my eyes and I feel almost embarrassed, but for what? How can her gaze be so... threatening?

"Headache, Rogelio?"

She asks. My stomach flips over countless times before I can even fathom an answer. How would she know? Kyle frowns at me and places a hand on my arm.

"You okay?"

I nod and glare at Astra, who shakes her head in response.

"I don't think you're okay, are you? How about you go get some rest while-"

I shake my head and grab Kyle's hand immediately. Something strange is going on. How else would she know about my head ache? How else would she separate me and Kyle?

Kyle squeezes my hand.

"He'll be okay."

He says, obviously thinking on the same wavelength as me. There have been many moments in our lives where having each other's backs was crucial, either for avoiding trouble or for wiggling back out of it, and this is no different. His hand holding mine gives me some kind of boost and I stand upright again, eager to hear Astra's explanation.

"You two are here, my darlings, because I need to lure Adora back in here somehow."

I roll my eyes but she holds up a finger, urging me to keep on listening.

"I need Adora, because I need She-Ra. My home planet, Latura, is weak and sad. We were the first ones that for left behind, outside the portal, free for the Horde's taking."

Something about her story sounds strange, but her tone is unfortunately very convincing.

"With She-Ra's power, I can use magic to revive my planet! I need her."

I give Kyle a certain look and he nods at me.

"Look, Astra, Adora isn't property. Neither is She-Ra. I'm sorry about your planet, but you can't steal our magic to revive it... It's wrong."

He says. I suddenly feel even more drawn to him than I was before. My Kyle, standing up to an enemy? An enemy we've never even met before? This is new, but interesting.

I nod in agreement when another stabbing sensation enters my skull, making me want to vomit. These are by far the worse headaches I've ever had, and I can't do anything about them. Kyle frowns with anxiety but I flash an unconvincing smile at him to calm him down.

"Rogelio, this is nonsense! You have to go to bed."

Astra declares. To of her glass workers make their way towards me and I try to push them awahz but it's useless. Kyle tries to follow me as I'm pushed out the door, but Astra grabs him by the arm and pulls him back inside.

'Kyle!'

I growl, more of a roar considering how loud it is. Kyle stretches his fingers out to me as best he can, but there's not much time before I'm dragged out into the empty corridor.

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# 19

Kyle's POV

The feeling is sickening, and the sound of Rogelio clawing at his captors sends shivers down my spine. I grab an axe from behind me on the wall and hold it out towards Astra, my arms shaking under it's unexpected weight. She laughs at me and takes it out of my hands, leaving me shaking with balled fists.

"What did you do to him?"

I ask, fighting the urge to cry. I've always been seen as a wimp, but I don't want her to know that. I swallow the lump in my throat and wince when I'm grabbed by the wrists by two glass guards.

I try to slip away but their grip tightens and their glassy fingers dig into my flesh, cutting it raw at some points. Astra waves towards an empty space in the wall, and without having time to react I'm tied to it, my arms pinned above my head on an empty hook.

"Let me go! Let us go! Why do we have to be separated?"

I shout. Astra smiles and folds her arms.

"Your Rogelio... He's quite boring, isn't he?"

I shake my head and glare at her.

"What? No!"

Despite the fact that I could easily be overpowered by her, this comment makes me want to fight.

"I mean, whatever. He's just a friend of yours."

My stomach leaps and I feel my hands balling up into fists.

"We're not just friends!"

My cheeks burn up and I regret saying it when she laughs at me. Why would I say something like that? Why am I always so defensive?

"Really? Are you sure?"

I know she's just trying to get under my skin, I know she wants to see me mad, I know it shouldn't bother me, but it does.

"Yeah, I'm pretty sure."

I grumble. Memories upon memories of me and Rogelio flash before my eyes. Talking, whispering, kissing, touching...

Astra's laugh snaps me out of it and I glare at her even more.

"Oh you foolish boy. I fear your attraction to him is merely... What's the word... animal."

I squirm uncomfortably.

"What would you know?"

She comes closer to me and lifts mt chin with a bony finger.

"I see two young men. One, a human. One, part human, but part lizard, too. I see that one of these two men can speak, and the other cannot. Tell me Kyle, how can you love each other emotionally if you can't communicate?"

I lunge at her but the restrains on my arms yank me back straight away. Calm down Kyle. Relax.

"You can't be. On a physical level, I understand. Your Rogelio looks... strong."

I close my eyes and try to shut her intrusive commentary out, but it's ultimately no use.

"So here's what I propose. You stay with me, and we get rid of him."

I open my eyes again.

"Set him free?"

She shakes her head.

"No. More like... disposing of him."

My eyes widen at her.

"No!"

Astra sighs and checks her nails.

"Kyle. When I first captured you, I could sense this energy radiating from you. Like... magic."

I shake my head and bite the inside of my cheek to stop myself from screaming at her.

"Did you know you were related to Adora?"

Everything goes silent. My stomach drops to the floor and my knees start to buckle under my weight.

"Stop lying to me. All you've done since we got here is lie."

I spit. She laughs at me.

"I wouldn't lie about such a thing. I mean..."

She starts to pace, each click of her heels makes me even more annoyed.

"I did make up the whole 'you're bait' story. You're not bait. In fact, you are more important to me than I was led to believe. With you and Adora... I'll be unstoppable."

I shake my head.

"Stop trying to convince me I'm somebody I'm not. The Horde did that to me-"

She claps her hands with a creepy grin and I feel sick.

"The Horde? Oh, why they're old friends of mine! I have some of their technology lying around."

My hands start to shake in my restraints and I take deep breaths to calm myself. She's lying, right? She has to be lying.

"If only you would believe me. Your strength, Kyle, is something only seen in one other on this planet. She-Ra."

She waits for my response with a gross expression.

"I'm don't have even half the strength She-Ra does.".

Astra comes closer to me, and sneers in my face.

"Kyle, of you don't comply with my orders, I won't hesitate to hurt Rogelio. I won't hesitate to destroy your home."

Her tone is much more menacing now, like a switch had been pulled inside her brain to change her attitude. I glare at her and clench my fists.

"What orders?"

A crystal guard comes through the door with a large sword in it's hands, it's golden handle and silver blade glistening under the white light. It's almost identical to She-Ra's sword, but without the gem in it's handle.

Astra takes it into her own hands and waves it before me with a smile.

"Use this sword to transform. Only then will I leave your Rogelio alone. If you're who I think you are, you will do great things for

me. If not... "

She unlocks my hands and I run at her in an instant, but she shoves the sword into my hands and takes a few steps away from me. The sword is heavy and I wobble with it in my grasp.

The door is only ten metres away, but there's a guard blocking it. Did I really think I could escape?

"What are you talking about? Who do you think I am?"

I ask, sweat dripping from my forehead and my palms. Astra holds up a small black device beside her face.

"Transform, or I'll send my guards to him."

My eyes widen and suddenly I'm willing to do whatever she's asking of me.

"Transform into what? What do you mean?"

My voice is raw and my pleading is desperate, only making her more amused.

"Did they not tell you?"

She says, her laugh echoing around the room. The hair on my arms stands up and I try not to drop the sword.

"Ever hear of He-Man?"

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# 20

Rogelio's POV

The pain hits me in the form of anger rather than sadness. Once the door shuts behind me I'm convinced it isn't real, that none of it has really happened and that I'll wake up from this twisted dream with nothing but a miniscule case of shivers.

Of course, I don't wake up, and the realisation that Kyle has been separated from me settles in. A surge of hatred for myself runs through me and I punch the wall with a glare on my face.

How could I have been so stupid? Why didn't I fight harder?

My head feels like it's splitting in half again and I let a tear fall down my cheek. I haven't cried since I was a child, but this moment seems fitting. I've lost my world, my everything, and all because I was too weak to fight.

It's ironic. Me, a soldier, scared of fighting after years of rest in love with a soldier who hasn't stopped fighting wars inside his head for years.

I'm too agitated to sit down, so instead I take large but quick steps around the cell, my tail feeling abnormally heavy and my teeth suddenly too sharp. Is this what it's like to be Kyle? Paying attention to so much details that everything slowly becomes painful?

A scratch coming from the ceiling makes me turn around. The spin makes my head go into frenzy but I manage to stand still. More scratching noises come and I realise they're in the vents. Have the princesses come to rescue us?

After being here for a while I forgot that was a possibility.

"Kyle? Rogelio?"

The voice is instantly familiar.

'Catra?'

Soon enough I can see her behind the silver grill of the vent, smiling down at me. I feel relieved that it was her who came for me, since she can understand every word I say almost as well as Lonnie can.

"Where's Kyle? What's wrong?"

Adora crawls up beside Catra and frowns down at me. I wipe my eyes with the back of my hand and look back to where the door would be.

'She has him.'

They share a look and Catra shakes her head.

"How many times do we have to come back here?"

She grumbles. Adora shoves her lightly and gestures towards the grill, which she slices open in an instant. The sound of the metal barrier crashing to the floor fills my ears but nobody comes to check in on me.

'I can't leave without him.'

I growl, backing away towards the door. Adora wears a pitied look, but she shakes her head anyways. My heart drops.

They obviously spent lot of time planning our rescue, and risked a lot sneaking in here, but am I willing to throw all of that away?

What will happen to Kyle if he comes back and I'm gone?

"Rogelio, come on! We'll have to rescue Kyle when we rescue the sword."

Catra hisses. They both stick their arms out in unison and I'm torn for what to do, my head turning from the wall to the vent a couple

of times before I'm interrupted by the sound of footsteps outside the cell. Adora gasps and waves her hand at me so I have no choice but to do it.

I have to leave.

I quickly slide a bedframe to the wall and stand on top of it, the vent now right in front of me. The wall starts to slide and I grip into Catra and Adora's hands, thanking them when they pull me up into the metal chute. My heart feels way too heavy.

The two girls start crawling but I look over my shoulder instead.

Kyle falls into the room and I open my mouth to call to him, but then I see the large sword he's dragging behind him. Astra peeks in and gasps up at the vent.

"Rogelio, go! Quickly!"

Kyle shouts, louder than I've ever heard him shout before. I start crawling and try to ignore the angry words tumbling from Astra's mouth.

"We're nearly there, come on!"

Catra says. We keep crawling.

I just left Kyle alone. I just left Kyle in there, alone. What sort of monster am I? He doesn't deserve this-

"Up here!"

Adora says, standing up and sliding a metal slate above her head open. She crawls out and so does Catra, eventually followed my me. I roll out onto the roof of the ship and suck in fresh, sharp breaths. The sky is dark, throwing me off, but the air is cool and refreshing.

'Kyle. I have to go back for Kyle.'

I growl. Catra shakes her head and waves for me to follow her and Adora. Glimmer smiles at me from where she stands waiting, but her expression drops when she catches my expression. Before I can stop it, I'm crying again.

"No... please tell me we don't have to go back in there again..."

Glimmer pants, extending her arm to us. We all place a hand on hers and within seconds we're back at Bright Moon.

Even though the other princesses are there, I don't care. I fall to one of the chairs in the huge room we're in and rest my face in my hands, letting the tears flow down my palms and trickle onto my arms.

Adora shakes her head so nobody questions me. Instead they all start to plan their third rescue mission for Kyle.

"Rogelio?"

I turn to see Lonnie sitting next to me. I smile at her and roughly get rid of the tears with my hand. She smiles at me and hugs me from the side.

"I decided to help out. I can't hide forever... and if Kyle can do it-"

We both laugh but then I'm hit with another wave of guilt. Lonnie pats my knee with a pitying expression.

"Was she treating you okay? You look like you havent slept for days."

I nod and smile as Imp crawls onto my foot. Lonnie groans and scoops him into her arms.

'I can't believe I just left him in there. It was so selfish.'

I grumble quietly. Lonnie sighs and shakes her head.

"I can't believe I didn't come to help sooner, I mean I didn't even check on you guys once. That's selfish. But you?"

She wipes a tear from my scaly skin and smiles at me.

"Nah, you're not selfish. You never were."

Imp repeats her words back to me and we both laugh. I try not to think about Kyle in there. I try not to think about what could be happening to him, because of me. Why did I go? Why did I leave?

The other princesses are still conferring and talking about plans, but Scorpia comes over to us and pats my shoulder with one of her claws.

"I'm sorry we couldn't get him out of there. We're all staying here tonight, to make sure we get enough planning in as possible. We'd like you to stay too."

She says with a smile. I nod and Lonnie just folds her arms, setting up a tough exterior as though she wasn't just comforting me.

"We think it's only fair that you get some rest, though. We plan, you sleep."

I open my mouth to argue but Scorpia stops me with a shake of her head. She nods over at Glimmer and then steers me out into the corridor, towards the room I stayed in last time.

"Seriously, try and get some sleep. This is going to be a long session, and you've barely closed your eyes by the looks of it."

I nod and try my best to smile when Scorpia closes the door behind her.

The bed is soft and unbelievably large, which only makes me feel more alone. Kyle is suppose to be next to me, but he isn't. Instead he's stuck with Astra and whatever that sword thing was. Is she hurting him? Did I hurt him? He called for me to go...

I can't fight off sleep for long, but the moment I close my eyes, all I can see his him.

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# 21

Kyle's POV

'You're okay. We're safe.'

Rogelio held me in his arms as I sobbed into his chest, trying not to make too much noise. I didn't know what he was saying at the time, or at least all I had heard was 'okay', but he told me later on.

We had just moved in to our new home and it was a huge change. The images were much scarier than they were when I slept in my soldier's bunk, and much clearer, so with that came an agonising night of dreams that put all sorts of images inside my head.

"Hordak... he's going to find us, Ro. He's going to get us..."

In that moment it felt like my mind was tearing me apart, which it was, but he kept me sane. He held me as I fell asleep, and didn't close his eyes himself until I was gone.

When I woke up the next morning, I felt a happiness beyond anything I'd ever felt before. Because I knew he was there for me, and I knew that I would be there for him, too.

But now I sit alone in the white cell, with nothing left of him but his scent that stuck to the mattresses. I lie on top of them and pull the blankets I was using to sleep on over me, and as I close my eyes I inhale his warm and familiar smell.

I'm so relieved he escaped, so happy that he's not imprisoned anymore, but a part of me is in despair. I'm alone.

The door of the cell slides open and I pull the blankets down to my nose and peek out. I'm expecting one of those creepy glass figures but instead I lock eyes with my captor, who smiles at me with nothing but malice in her eyes. I grip the blanket to make

sure it stays over me, but she doesn't come close enough to disturb me anyways.

"Your lot sure are a handful, aren't they? I was debating whether or not to do this, but..."

She fixes her hair and licks her teeth before continuing her sentence.

"They don't understand the severity of what they've done. I don't think they understand the fact that I need them."

I glare at her and breathe in more of Rogelio's scent, which is all I need to refrain from lashing out. For now.

"Well, are you going to come with me?"

She says, gesturing out into the corridor. I shake my head but she narrows her eyes at me.

"Come with me."

I reluctantly stand up and hug myself in an attempt at comfort. The sword is lying beside my bed on the floor but I try to block it from my vision and thoughts as best as I can, not wanting to think about anything other than the present, and what's happening right now.

Don't think about Rogelio, dont think about whoever that He-man guy is, don't think about She-ra's sword in the hall.

"Here we are."

I gulp when I find myself face to face with a huge glassy screen. Astra taps some buttons and within seconds it lights up, casting a soft glow over the walls surrounding us. My stomach drops when I realise what's on the screen.

The Waste. But not just the Waste. It's the valley of the lost, my home. Our home.

"Stop tormenting us!"

I cry, my throat burning. Astra laughs and taps some more buttons, which makes the floor vibrate suddenly. I fall over and shake my head at her.

"No! What are you doing!"

She glares at where I lie on the floor, tears streaming down my cheeks.

"You refuse to transform into He-Man. Your friends refuse to give me their magic."

"Stop talking about he-man! I don't know who that is!"

She rolls her eyes and points at the screen before us. My stomach drops to the floor.

Fire. Explosions, and fire. My home, the entire valley, is suddenly swallowed by a red and orange mass of flames. Smoke billows into the air, blacking out the cameras, but the  image is ingrained in my mind.

"You're a monster!"

I shout, leaping from the floor and running at Astra. She folds her arms with a smirk and I can't help but notice the screen is completely black now, only showing my reflection.

My golden and glowing reflection.

I flinch away from her and gawk at the tall figure staring back at me, his build much stronger than mine and his hair much shorter.

"You destroyed my home... for this? You're so sick!

I shake my head over and over again, hoping it's not really gone, hoping that all those people aren't really dead.

But they are.

Whatever pain fuels me, whatever sadness and disgust runs through me is powerful enough to give me some hope.

I clench my fists and turn on my heels, sprinting as fast as I can down the corridor. There's a sword in my hands now, and I'm not sure how it got there, but it's enough to push me past the round of guards that try to stop me. I push them with my unusually muscly arms and keep running towards the door of the ship.

I'm almost there.

I'm so close.

I lift the sword as high as I can above my head and plunge it into the steel door, the horrible crunching sound making me wince but only for a moment. Footsteps get louder behind me and I force myself through the gap, cutting my leg in the process.

I'm expecting fresh air so I suck in, relieved, but what I inhale is the complete opposite.

It's smoke. Lots and lots of smoke.

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# 22

Rogelio's POV

Sunlight pours in from the window above my head and floods into the room, making everything in it's path sparkle and glow. I sit up slowly and scratch my head. I didn't bother to out the blanket over me last night, so the bed is still made perfectly. I run my hand over the smooth material and stand up.

Just as I start to yawn the door swings open, revealing a distressed Lonnie. Her eyes are bloodshot and her hair eyebrows are creased in a way that makes her look confused.

"Rogelio- they- she-"

I run over to her to give her a hug but she grabs my arm and pulls me after her down the corridor at full speed. I run with her and try not to overthink why she could be crying.

Everybody stands at the end of the corridor with pained looks, but nobody says a word except for Glimmer.

"Everybody hold on."

And we do. I'm so confused, so disturbed by the sudden shift in moods, but once we arrive to our destination it all becomes clear.

Smoke.

Clouds of dark smoke waft out of the valley and into the air, caking the rubble down there with a thick layer of ash. Everything is gone, destroyed.

My home is gone.

All of those people, our old neighbours, our friends, are gone.

Lonnie falls to her knees and I stand behind her, both of our eyes trained on our old home. The tears start falling before I can register them, trickling down my neck and making my shirt collar damp.

The princesses and our other friends are behind us, watching the scene, but nobody tries to bother us. I sit next to her and a confused imp crawls to my lap and clutches to my shirt while I shake my head over and over again, hoping it's not really gone, hoping that all those people aren't really dead.

But they are.

"She destroyed it all..."

Adora whispers, walking to the edge of the cliff and looking down into the mess.

We sit for what feels like hours while the others try to talk to each other in hushed tones behind us. After a while Imp leaves me for Lonnie and I stand up. Scorpia pats my back.

"I'm so sorry, Rogelio."

I nod and look down at the wreakage once more, but I'm interrupted by an excited Frosta.

"Look, over there!"

She exclaims, pointing in the direction of where the ship would be. I turn to face it, expecting a guard, or even Astra herself, but what I'm looking at it much stranger.

A boy, a young man, who must be at least 6 feet tall is walking towards us, dragging some kind of sword behind him. His hair is tight but still somehow flowy, and the outfit he's wearing resembles only one I've ever seen before. She-Ra's.

"Who are you?"

Adora says, but as she does so he starts glowing, and shrinks to a significantly shorter height.

When he comes closer, I recognise him instantly.

'Kyle?'

Kyle limps over to us and drags the sword behind him, obviously in pain. He hands the sword to Adora and falls to the floor.

I rush over to him and try to speak, but he croaks out something before I have the chance.

"He-Man."

He says, and his eyes close.

I start to panic, not sure what just happened, or how he got out, but the others remain calm enough to formulate a plan.

"We need to get back to he castle."

Somebody says. I hold Kyle to my chest and in the blink of an eye we're back at Bright Moon, and I'm in the middle of the war room floor with an unconscious Kyle in my arms.

I have out relieved but terrified breaths.

"Oh no, his leg!"

Perfuma gasps. I look down to his leg and feel myself go tense.

Blood is flowing at an alarming rate from his thigh, where there's a huge gash. It looks like it was cut by something extremely sharp, like glass or metal, and the thought of how much pain he must be in makes mepre upset than I would have anticipated.

"Adora, figure out what that sword means."

Glimmer says, staring at the open wound. She places her arm gently onto mine and another to Kyle's forehead, as though she's

comforting him in his slumber.

I try to calm myself but as I'm slowing my breaths I notice something strange. The gash on his leg, despite how big it is, is slowly closing itself with a slightly golden shimmer. Glimmer's eyes widen and we share a confused look, before the others crowd around us.

Kyle sits up suddenly and coughs out a dry breath, making everybody jump. He grabs the space on his leg where the cut was and frowns up at me.

"Kyle? What happened in there? Was that She-Ra?"

Lonnie asks, kneeling before him. He massages his temple and closes his eyes.

"I want to explain everything, I do, but my head..."

Bow offers his hand to help him stand up. When he stands, we each hold one of his arms and help him stand.

"He needs rest. Tomorrow, we'll discuss everything."

Bow says.

As Kyle's head falls onto my shoulder, the Princesses let out a collective sigh.

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# 23

Rogelio's POV

I hold Kyle's hand in mine as he sleeps. Transfixed by his soft breaths, I watch as his chest rises and falls slowly with every passing second.

Sunlight, one of the things that Bright Moon has always had plenty of fills the room like it usually does, only this time it's shimmering glow reminds me of my home, and of how I'm never going to wake up in our shabby little excuse for a flat ever again.

Every now and then I cough a little, like the smoke from the scene has attached itself to my lungs, and it does nothing but remind me of how that woman ruined everything for us.

"Rogelio?"

I look up to Kyle and smile at him. His eyelids flutter open slowly at first but then he looks around and surveys the room.

"I was hoping it was a dream. I thought we'd wake up back home."

Home. The word feels like a punch to the stomach, but I try my best to stay strong.

'Yeah, me too.'

He brings my hand to his lips and kisses it softly with a smile.

"We'll get through this together. All of this. Astra, He-Man, The Valley."

His tone is gentle but his words stand out to me just the same.

'He-Man? Is that who you were yesterday?'

I ask, mainly to take my mind off our old home but also because I'm worried for him. He nods and scooches over in the bed, patting the space behind him for me to sit on. I crawl up next to him and his head falls to my shoulder again.

"I don't know what it is yet, but It has to be something to do with She-Ra..."

His voice falters like he's thinking about adding something on, but he doesn't. If we weren't friends with Adora, maybe this would have come as a huge shock, but for some strange reason none of this feels crazy to me. I suppose being surrounded by magic would do that to you.

'She blew up the valley, didn't she?'

I ask. Kyle sits up straight and starts biting his lip.

"Yeah."

I nod and wrap my arm around his shoulders.

'You don't have to talk about it, but I think we're going today.'

He looks up at me with furrowed brows.

"To the valley?"

I nod and every single ounce of pain and worry inside of Kyle's head flashes across his face, only lasting a couple of seconds before he smiles through it.

"Okay."

We sit for a while and only stir when there's an aggressive knock on the door. We recognise it instantly.

Lonnie pops her head in and smiles as she runs over to sit on the end of the bed.

"Hey Kyle, you doing okay?"

She asks and Kyle nods in reply. She leans over and punches me in the arm with a smirk.

"You better be taking good care of him Rogelio."

I roll my eyes and laugh with them. How lucky were we to have saved Lonnie and Imp?

'Are we going to the valley?'

I ask, desperately trying to push the image of all of our neighbours dying as far away as possible. Lonnie nods and pats Kyle's foot through the blanket.

"We're leaving after breakfast."

—— (after breakfast) ——

We let go of Glimmers arms and all of a sudden the ground feels wrong. My legs go heavy with each step I take and the dust and ash caking the wreakage is flying up into the air with every heart-wrenching crunch of our feet.

Catra, Adora, Bow and Glimmer were the only ones who came with us, but even the audience of four people feels like too much. Lonnie starts for where she would have lived and me and Kyle follow suit, trying our best to make out the streets and turns heading towards our place.

Kyle's fingers lock with mine even tighter the closer we get, but he's practically squeezing my hand when we see it.

Our door, half singed and broken, lies in pieces on the ground. I kneel down and pick up the small wedge that we used to keep the door shut. It survived completely.

Kyle turns away from me and holds his face in his hands, his breaths loud and getting faster. I reach my hand out to comfort him but he turns back to me and shakes his head. Tears decorate his cheeks.

"Sorry. We have to see what else survived."

Behind us, Catra and Adora stand with upset expressions.

We wade through the charred bricks and chunks of wood until eventually we decide to search through it. Dropping to our knees, I instantly find something.

My fingers run over the creases in the smooth material before pulling it out. Kyle lets out a shuddery sigh and the sight of it.

'Your Horde uniform.'

He nods and takes it from me, setting it beside him with the wedge.

"Hey, is this any use to you guys?"

Catra pulls out a thin piece of canvas from the rocks and turns it to face us. We both smile and nod. The painting.

It's added to the pile.

I stand up and frown at the crushed and splintered bed that managed to remain somewhat visible after the bombing. Who knew there could be so many memories attached to one single piece of furniture? Kyle stares at it for a while and his cheeks flush pink.

'I can't believe it's all destroyed.'

I growl. He stands up beside me and nods, sliding his fingers over the now dusty bedframe and flicking the stuff from his fingers with a frown.

"I thought I was sad at first but now... now I'm just mad."

His voice cracks like it used to when we were teenagers. Our brooding is interrupted when Bow, Glimmer and Lonnie come

running towards us, panting and smiling. Smiling? Why would they be smiling?

Catra must have been thinking the same thing, because she frowns at them in confusion.

Bow leans over and grabs his knees to get his breath back while Lonnie smiles at me and Kyle.

"We found something. People, real people."

Kyle looks up at me with raised eyebrows and Adora gasps a little in surprise.

"They escaped?"

Glimmer nods and replies between quick gasps of air.

"They saw her guards planting the bombs during the night, and evacuated to another part of the waste. They're safe."

It feels like a huge weight has suddenly been lifted off my shoulders. They're safe. Kyle laughs in relief. The sound of his happiness, even if it only lasts for a moment, is enough to fill me with a happiness of my own.

"We only saw one person, but he explained everything to us. Glimmer brought him back to their new village."

Bow says.

"He said they're sorry about you two. They noticed you were gone but they didn't know you were up there."

I nod and so does Kyle, a tiny smile tugging at his lips.

"We can always get more furniture, a new home, new stuff... so something about the rest of the valley being safe makes this all a little easier."

He says quietly. I nod and scoop up our three finds, the only things that seemed to have made it through the explosions. They're light to carry, but they have an odd weight to them, too.

This is a new start for us. A start where we can take Astra down and go into a new stage together.

Now's our chance to win.

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# 24

Kyle's (dream) POV

I wake up in my bed, with Rogelio sleeping soundly by my side. The sun is pouring it's light through the window, like it usually does, and I smile to myself. This is home.

Every inch of sunlight that reaches into our room makes everything sparkle and relieved that it's all still here. I scratch my head and try to shake out the nightmare I had before.

"Kyle."

I turn to Rogelio, but he's still asleep. Did I really think it was him who could have said my name?

No, I must be imagining things again. More flashbacks.

I creep out of the room and towards the kitchen when I hear the voice again, only this time coming from outside.

Without making too much noise I kick the wedge under the door away and open it. Nobody's there.

"Hello?"

I call, but there's no reply. An older neighbour of ours walking by gives me a curt nod.

"Morning Horde soldier."

I nod back but something feels off. Nobody, not even people in the Crimson Waste, likes to talk about the Horde. I haven't been called Horde soldier in... years.

"Kyle. The sword."

This time the voice is much louder, but the street is even emptier than it was the first time.

I decide to follow it.

Despite my feet being bare, I can't feel he ground underneath me. The stones I run over don't hurt and even the hottest cobblestone doesn't burn my toes.

The voice calls me again and I turn around the corner, running down a tight alleyway towards the darker side of the Valley.

I stop when something shiny catches my eye.

A huge sword with a golden handle and silver blade is lodged in a pile of rubble, giving off a strange glow.

Is this what's been calling me?

"Kyle... we need you..."

I gulp and take a few steps closer to it, reaching out to touch it's handle. The second my finger tip touches it everything goes white.

"Kyle. You are He-Man. Astra wants your power, and She-Ra's power, for herself."

What looks like a hologram says. I shake my head and try to stop my pounding headache, but as expected it doesn't work. The hologram reaches out to me but when I try to reach back, she pulls away.

"You need your sister's help. Adora. Adora."

I squint at her.

"I don't have... Adora's not..."

I wake up with a jolt and practically throw myself out of bed. The room is big, too big. I'm not at home... my home is... gone.

Rogelio stares at me with a shocked expression from a stool next to the bed, his eyebrows raised.

'Kyle?'

I smile at him and clutch my stomach for support.

"I'll explain everything later, I promise. But now... I need to talk to Adora."

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"I'll explain everything later, I promise. But now... I need to talk to Adora."

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# 25

Kyle's POV

"Kyle? Are you okay?"

Adora sits a couple of seats away from me and I smile at her to scare away my own anxious thoughts.

The war room is empty, and because of this the windows are free to cast their warmth and light over everything. Our voices echo, but not too much, fading away after a second or two.

"I think I'm good."

I shake my head and straighten up to get the question out.

"Is there anywhere I can go to find out about... magic?"

Adora nods and let's out a small giggle.

"I mean yeah, Etheria's full of it."

I frown at her and her expression hardens as if she knows what I'm thinking.

"It's about He-Man and She-Ra, isn't it."

I raise my eyebrows and my mouth opens slightly with surprise. She sighs and messes with her ponytail before standing up.

"I've been having these weird dreams, like the visions I had when I first touched the sword. They keep repeating the same thing over and over again; He-Man. You need to help He-Man."

Her voice is waving, strained from worrying, so I stand up and pat her arm encouragingly.

"I didn't know who else to ask, and since you're She-Ra..."

I decide not to mention the whole 'sister' thing. With everything that's been going on, between being held captive to escaping to my home being destroyed... it's too much. Adora smiles at me and waves for me to follow her out into the hallway.

"I know exactly where we have to go."

I nod and follow her promptly around a sharp corner where we find Catra sitting on the bench of a balcony, drinking in the fresh morning sun. She turns to us and smiles. Her hair is short, but not as short as it was when Horde Prime first cut it off. The gentle breeze runs through it and it nearly brushes off the top of her shoulders as it sways.

"Catra, Kyle and I have to find answers. You wanna come? Rogelio can come, too."

She smiles at me and I smile back. Catra stands up and joins hands with Adora.

"Sure. Not that I like going places with you guys, I just have nothing better to do."

She says. Adora rolls her eyes and laughs, the couple following me back to where I left Rogelio. I push the door open a little and smile at him, seemingly making him more relieved. He must have been worrying about me.

"Hey Ro, Catra, Adora and I are going to try and figure out this whole He-Man thing. You wanna come?"

I already know he wants to before I can finish my sentence, so it's no surprise to me when he links my arm and follows Catra and Adora with me towards the main castle doors.

After a few minutes of following, we come across Glimmer and Bow in the gardens. They smile at us and Adora points over at the woods.

"We have to go to Razz! We'll get back as soon as possible!"

She calls, and we follow her into the thicket of trees. She and Catra start talking to one another, so I take the opportunity to explain as much as I can to Rogelio.

"I guess you want to know how I got out."

I say. He smiles down at me and nods.My foot catches in a small plant with glowing tubers but he catches me as I fall, reminding me of how much he cares. Our fingers intertwine once more.

"When you escaped, I was relieved, but obviously Astra wasn't."

Rogelio nods and helps me over a particularly large tree root jutting out of the soil.

"See when the guard thing took you away from me, she was telling me all of these things about He-Man, and about how she could sense my magic. I wasn't listening to her, so then after you left I guess it tipped her over the edge."

Rogelio grumbles a guilty 'sorry' but I shake my head.

"You did the right thing. After you were well gone she brought me into this huge room with a screen and everything, telling me that everyone was gonna pay."

Cara and Adora continue their excited chatter whilst I recap the confusing evening. Or was it morning? My mind hasn't been paying too much attention to time lately.

"I wouldn't transform into He-Man, so she..."

Rogelio nods, getting the gist fairly easily. I don't realise there are tears falling down my face until he wipes them away with his gentle hand.

"It's my fault."

I whisper. Rogelio shakes his head in disagreement and wraps a sturdy arm around my shoulders, pulling me closer to his side and

helping my tears to slow down.

'The only person who's fault it is, is Astra's.'

He says. I nod and wrap my arms around his torso while we walk.

"I got so upset about the valley that I guess I just... transformed. After that the sword appeared in my hands and there was no stopping me. I was fueled by fear."

The words come out in a much darker tone than expected, but Rogelio continues to comfort me, even playing with my hair occasionally and sending happy shudders down my spine.

'Im just so glad you're okay. I felt so guilty for just leaving you like that.'

I look up at him and frown. My vision is hazy from tears and from the blinding sun but the canopy of trees soon helps.

"Ro, you were right to go. The princesses probably put a lot of time into that plan."

Ro nods and kisses my head softly.

'We're together now, and that's all that matters. Also, I'm really liking the idea of this He-Man guy.'

He wiggles his eyebrows and I flush red, shoving him away and laughing out loud from the rude remark.

"Catra can hear you!"

I whisper, but he just laughs.

'She's with She-Ra, I'm sure she understands.'

I don't think I can get redder in the face now, especially when Catra snickers and looks over her shoulder to me.

"We're here!"

Adora says, and I sigh out of relief. Catra falls behind with Rogelio and I go with Adora to what must be the entrance of a small cave or a very large hole in the bottom of a tree.

Adora elbows me lightly and I smile at her, not entirely sure if it's fake or not.

"Razz? It's Adora!"

She calls. I can barely get in an extra breath before the sheet covering the hole is lifted and a small old woman comes out to smile at us. Adora tries to speak again but she grabs my hands and squeezes them with excitement.

"Adam! Oh, I was waiting for you!"

I shake my head and try to correct her but she lifts a knobbly finger to my mouth and whisks me into her home. The others follow and watch with amused expressions as the small woman pulls at my arms and pokes my face. My stomach feels a little squirmy. This is who's supposed to help me?

"Razz, Kyle is like me. He's-"

Adora gets cut off by her.

"He-Man! Silly Mara, I already know that."

Catra and Rogelio laugh a little when me and Adora share a tiresome expression.

"Uh, Razz?"

She turns to me and hands me a long broom while I'm speaking.

"I just wanna know how to transform into him."

She laughs and I yelp when the broom in my hands wiggles free and starts to sweep the floor.

Adora coughs on some of the dust being sent into the air.

"Do you know how we're related? I mean, there's obviously a connection somewhere, right?"

With this question my palms get sweaty again. My dreams, Astra... they both told me the same thing. She-Ra and He-Man being siblings I understand, but me and Adora?

Razz pushes me closer to Adora and then observes both of our faces in deep thought. Then she smiles at me.

"You know, don't you Adam?"

I want to correct her but I know it's no use so I stay quiet and shake my head. Razz frowns and her broom hits me on the back of the head. Rogelio and Catra laugh but I don't.

"Hey!"

The old woman takes one of my hands and then one of Adora's and smiles at us both.

"Kyle. Your dreams aren't just dreams, you know. They're messages. Instructions."

I gulp and flit my gaze to Adora, who's frowning at us both with the most confused expression I've ever laid eyes on. My dreams weren't lying, and neither was Astra.

"Adora's my sister."

I mumble. Adora's eyebrows shoot up her forehead.

"What? Me and you? What?"

Catra and Rogelio, not hearing what I said at all obviously wear worried looks so I say it again, only louder.

"Adora's my sister. I'm Adora's brother."

Everybody is silent for what feels like an eternity. It doesn't sound as though it would change anything, having a sibling like bond

since we were children anyways, but for some reason it does. Saying it out loud seems to have clicked something with Adora.

Razz breaks the silence with another smack to the back of my head.

"Silly Adam! How could you forget your own family like that?"

I massage the back of my head and pout like a child while Adora tries to get answers from her.

"But... that means Kyle came through the portal with me. That means..."

Razz takes one of Adora's hands again and pats it gently.

"Adora, This isn't the first time you've been lied to about your past."

She opens her mouth to continue but Catra interrupts, her eyes shaped like slits.

"So, hang on. Kyle and Adora are brother sister? And Kyle is this He-Man guy?"

Razz ignores her and starts tending to some plants hanging from the wall. Catra pokes me and I glare at her.

"Kyle? This-"

She tries to poke me again but I show her an icy stare.

"Yes, Catra."

She sticks her tongue out at me and Rogelio smiles. Razz turns around suddenly and the four of us flinch.

"The sword!"

She exclaims. I pull it hastily but wearily from the sheath on my back and she claps her hands with a huge grin on her face.

"Yes, Kyle! Adam! He-Man!"

I shake my head at her but she closes her hands around mine, which are clasped on the handle of the sword. Adora bites her lip and stares at the ground in what looks like deep thought or concentration.

"You need to say the words, Kyle."

I sigh out of pure exhaustion.

"But I don't know what the words are, Razz!"

Rogelio and Catra glance at each other with worried expressions but Razz smiles at me still.

"By the power of Grayskull! Of course you knew that, Adam!"

Adora looks up at me and smiles, her previous look of confusion now gone without a trace. I hold the sword up above my head and try not to topple over with it's weight.

"By the power of Grayskull!"

I'm suddenly taken over by a blinding white light, and I can feel my body spinning around as I transform. When I can see again I can tell by the look on Rogelio's face that it worked.

I look down at my hands and lift them in front of my face to take a better look, amazed but concerned by how different they are. Razz pokes me with her broom again but gently this time.

"You have the power to get She-Ra's sword back, Kyle. And once you do that..."

She smiles at Adora, who smiles back.

"Astra will have no choice but to leave."

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# 27

Chapter Notes

this chapter gets steamy, but not explicit. if you’re not into sexy stuff, you can skip this chapter because it’s not plot relevant / centred!!

Kyle's POV

"By the power of Grayskull!"

I whisper shout. The sky outside is completely dark and everybody else in the castle is either asleep or in their rooms. The air is silent but not too silent, the odd sound of birdsong and rustling of trees making appearances.

Rogelio stares up at me from where he's sitting on the bed, his expression a cross of admiration and excitement. I scratch the back of my neck and put the sword down, still feeling weird as He-Man. Despite feeling weird, however, I have a new confidence. A new drive.

"Astra took so much from us. Our home, even our freedom for a bit... but she couldn't take us away."

I say, my heart beating faster and faster with each passing second. Rogelio nods and I notice his eyes traveling from my feet up to my face quickly but obviously.

'You're stuck with me.'

He growls. I smile at him and look over my shoulder towards the door, making sure there's nobody there. As expected, there isn't. When I turn back to face him, Rogelio smirks at me. We don't have to say anything to know where this is going.

"I dunno about you, but something about everyone being safe, and about us being free from Astra is making me really happy."

I say, moving closer to him. It feels unfamiliar to be taller than him, but there's something really exciting about the new confidence that comes with it.

'Me too.'

Rogelio says. I look over to the door again and smirk back at him when I realise that we have the whole night to ourselves. He looks me up and down again and that's enough to send shivers around my whole body, pushing me to climb over to him. He tenses when I lean in to his neck and attach my lips to his skin, planting kisses down to his shirt collar.

"This is usually your job."

I say quietly with a snicker. He laughs a little, only making me want to do more.

'What about your shirt?'

He says, eyeing my torso. When I take it off and throw it with my cape onto the ground I can't help but smile at his reaction. I've gained quite a few muscles in the transformation on my arms and legs, but they're most prominent in my stomach.

Rogelio pulls his shirt off too and suddenly I'm even more driven than before, wrapping my arms around his neck in seconds. My skin tingles where our bare chests brush against each other, but it's nothing compared to the shivers that course through me when he runs his fingers through my hair.

I start to giggle, something that usually happens in these scenarios, and Rogelio starts laughing too, so we have to try our best to be as quiet as possible given it's the middle of the night.

Somewhere between the giggling and hugging Rogelio finds his way on top of me, leaving small love bites in a trail from behind my ear right down to my collarbone. I cover my mouth to keep from laughing or letting out any other questionable sounds while he keeps at it, sending waves of pleasure through my veins.

"These better dissapear."

I whisper, tracing the marks with my fingers. Rogelio smirks and continues down my stomach, making me squirm with excitement, but in seconds I can feel myself sleeping away.

"Sorry."

I say quietly, transforming back into Kyle before I can stop it from happening. Rogelio smiles up at me and shakes his head.

'I fell in love with you, not He-Man.'

I go red from embarrassment but really I'm just happy, elated even, to have Rogelio here with me. Despite all the odds, all the obstacles that were thrown at us, we're here now, together, and that's all the I need to know to keep me sane right now.

I reach up to my neck and glare at a smirking Rogelio when I find that the hickeys are still imprinted in my skin, but eventually I'm smiling down at him again.

"Just like old times."

I whisper. He nods and allows his hands to find mine, squeezing them gently and making me giggle silently again.

'Just like old times.'

When he leaves a kiss under my bellybutton there's no need for any more words.

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# 28

Kyle's POV

Chatter from the best friend's squad fills the room as we eat our breakfast. The table is huge and round, distancing them from me, Rogelio and Lonnie. Imp sits with his arms crossed on the table beside Lonnie's plate, but she ignores his pouting, her eyes fixed on my neck.

"Yikes, what happened there?"

She asks, reaching out to touch the small bruises. I smack her hand away and cover them with my hand, trying not to make the fact that I'm blushing that obvious. Lonnie frowns at me, and then to Rogelio, which tells her all she needs to know. Her confused look shifts to amusement in a matter of seconds.

"You're looking quite tired Kyle."

She teases. I shove another spoonful of porridge into my mouth and glare at her. Imp repeats her words with an even louder voice and I flinch, making Rogelio laugh into his toast.

The other four laughing across from us aren't paying attention to our conversation, so I decide to say something back to Lonnie.

"I'm tired because I was up half the night trying to figure out who He-Man is."

I say, very matter-of-factly. She covers Imp's ears and smirks as she replies.

"So was Ro trying to figure him out, too?"

She waves a finger towards my neck and then dares to wiggle her eyebrows at me. I groan and hide my face in my hands, letting Rogelio handle her. This I did not miss.

'Stop being so inappropriate!'

He growls at her. She opens her mouth to add something but he cuts her off.

'But yes, I was.'

My head snaps towards him with my mouth agape and Lonnie starts to laugh at me.

"Kyle."

The three of us look over at the others but they aren't facing us.

"Kyle."

Lonnie gasps and smiles at Imp.

"He said Kyle! He said Kyle in his own voice!"

Me and Rogelio smile to each other and then to him. My heart feels heavy for the little creature, especially when he crawls across Lonnie's lap to sit on mine. I laugh and give him a small hug.

"Kyle!"

We all laugh again. He stands up on top of my legs and decides to stick is finger right into one of the marks on my neck, making me yelp in pain.

"Ow!"

Lonnie can't control her laughter, and even Rogelio is trying to hold in his. Catra snickers from across the table and I immediately cover my neck with my hand again.

"Stop picking on me, pick on Ro!"

While the others are still talking Catra raises her eyebrows at me and taps her neck with a smirk. I push my empty bowl forwards and hide my head in my arms while they laugh at me still.

Although they're trying to embarrass me, it feels good. Not the embarrassment, but the fact that we can still have fun after all these years, and after all that's happened in the last while.

I can feel Rogelio patting my head and ruffling my hair up so I decide to stay with my head down for a while, hoping that Lonnie and Catra will back off.

For some reason my mind starts to fill up with horrible thoughts and questions that I haven't thought about since I escaped the ship.

Adora's my sister. Should I be talking to her more?

What if Astra is blowing somewhere else up right now?

How will we get the sword back from her?

'Kyle?'

I sit up and look at Rogelio, who's observing me with a worried frown. I smile and his frown slowly starts to fade. Lonnie has gone back to eating so I take one of his hands and kiss it like I did yesterday, sending tingles throughout my lips. He smiles at me and does the same thing to my hand.

"Alright you two we get it."

Lonnie says jokingly, punching me in the arm. I glare at her for what feels like the hundredth time today and am relieved when Bow calls across the table to us.

"Okay, so we were thinking... since Kyle can still use magic in the ship that must mean that She-Ra can, too."

He says. Lonnie shakes her head.

"But isn't her sword-"

"Her sword is still in there, yeah. So the problem must be that whatever restraints the sword is in is stopping Adora from conjuring it again."

I nod and glance over at Adora. I don't think I'll ever look at her the same way again. The only way I looked at her before was a friend, an old teammate from some of the worst years of my life, but now? She's literally my family, and it's strange.

She catches my gaze and smiles, forcing me to look away again.

"While you guys were gone to Razz yesterday, Bow and I went back to Entrapta's. She gave us all the information we need to get Astra out of here."

Glimmer says, smiling at all of us. We nod for her to continue, so she does.

"The ship has a cockpit, of course, at the furthest point from the entrance. In there-"

She clicks a button in the table and a pink holographic plan of the ship pops up, making us all jump.

"There's an override key. Since the ship is a first one's, all we need to do is stick either She-Ra or He-Man's sword in it, and the ship will go wherever you tell it to."

Sweat starts to form in beads on my forehead again.

"But if we tell it to go... won't we go with it? And what if Astra leaves herself while we're in there?"

Catra nods at my questions, agreeing with me for once. Bow sighs and and does something with the hologram so that it now shows us a long corridor.

"It'll be hard, but once you tell it to leave you'll have a minute to get out of there."

My chest feels heavy again.

"So we have to go in there, get She-Ra's sword, distract Astra, override the ship, and then escape?"

I ask. My voice is hopeful, hopeful that it's not going to be that difficult, but unfortunately Glimmer nods.

"We're sorry, Kyle, but being He-Man... well it's like She-Ra. There's a lot of responsibility."

I nod and fall back into the chair, my brain losing a fight to a hazy memory that comes to the front of my mind, drowning out the voices of discussion around me.

-

"Cadet Kyle. You are no longer permitted to run errands with Rogelio."

Shadow Weaver said. Her voice was drawn out at the end of her sentence and she spoke with her usual sing-song accent, only making everything worse.

Lonnie and Rogelio stood at each side of me but I felt alone, singled out. Shadow Weaver's eyes, or at least the eyes in her mask, got thinner and more slit-like as she waited for me to say something.

"Do you understand?"

I nodded and Lonnie glanced at me with pain in her eyes. Rogelio was staring at the floor feeling guilty, but what was there to be guilty for? All he did was hold my hand, and it was only for a couple of seconds before she found us.

"Sorry Shadow Weaver."

I mumbled. She waved her hand for Lonnie to leave and looked at Rogelio and I with what came off as disappointment, but was

probably seething rage. She reached out and tapped the horde emblem on my uniform, making me feel squirmish.

"There's a lot of responsibility that comes with being a soldier, cadets. If you allow yourselves to be distracted like Catra and Adora..."

We glanced at each other but she snapped her fingers to get us to focus on her.

"We'll have to dispose of you."

-

'Do you understand?'

Her cold voice plays on repeat in my head and threatens to make me mad. Understanding. There's so much to understand, too much to understand. My mind races as I overthink, coming up with all of the horrible things that could go wrong with this 'mission'.

I want to be home again. I don't want to be He-Man, and I don't want to feel like a burden in Bright Moon anymore.

But I have no choice.

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# 29

Rogelio's POV

"C'mon Kyle, one more!"

The sound of the metal blade clashing with the punching bag strung from the ceiling fills the room, making both me and Catra flinch. The smell of sweat is putrid, but neither of us would pass down the chance to see He-Man and Adora in training.

"He's not bad actually."

Catra says, taking a swig from Adora's water bottle. I nod in agreement, beads of sweat forming on my forehead just from looking at him. I know he would never be able to do so much as Kyle, and it's strange seeing him so precise for once.

'It's a little weird to get used to.'

I say, making sure I'm quiet enough so that Kyle can't hear me. He ducks under Adora's arm as she swings at him and jabs the sword into the punching bag.

"Yeah, I getcha."

After what feels like only a couple of seconds more of exercise Kyle shifts back to himself and collapses into an exhausted heap on the floor. Adora grabs her water from Catra and downs it in one go.

"Okay, so He-Man is just as fit as She-Ra."

She says between gasps. Of course he is, I think, but I wouldn't dare say that to anyone else. When Kyle drags himself over to me I laugh with the sight of him falling dramatically into my arms with a huff of hot air escaping his lips, and secretly adore the way his hair falls even messier after a workout than it usually does, each

blonde strand like a golden thread framing his pale but flushed face.

"Why... are you staring... at me?"

He pants. I smile at him and shrug, sure that he'll understand eventually. Adora slaps him on the back encouragingly and sits next to us on the bench, pushing Catra over to make room. Maybe it's just the knowledge that Adora's Kyle's sister messing with my head, but they look scarily alike, each glint in their eyes even more similar and every strand of blonde hair only looking more the same as time passes on.

"One training session before the mission isn't exactly good, but it'll do."

Adora says with a smile. Kyle grumbles something and hides his face in my chest again.

'Maybe for once all his training with the Horde will have payed off.'

I growl. Catra understands me and snickers when Kyle shoots me a glare, but Adora just looks to the floor silently.

"Are you two okay? I don't mean it like that, it's just... have you even had time to process anything?"

She says, catching me off guard. Her voice wavers as she speaks and sends a twinge of anxiousness through my head. Are we? Kyle looks up at me and out eyes remain locked for a few seconds, before looking back to the floor. I frown at the side of his face and decide not to say anything, not finding the right words even if I wanted to. Adora smiles and pats my hand.

"Sorry, I'm just worried. Sisterly things, I suppose."

The four of us sit in an uncomfortable silence for a while before Kyle decides we should probably go back to our room.

The room is beautiful as always. Being midday the sun is perched high above the castle on it's sparkling throne, hiding away from all of the chaos that will soon be brought over the crimson waste tomorrow. I stare at it through the large glass doors and wish for a second that I could watch from above, too. I glance over at Kyle, who's lying on the floor, and lie next to him. Our heads are side by side buy our bodies stick out in opposite directions.

'How are you doing?'

I grumble, as quietly as I can. Kyle glances at me from the corner of his eye and I notice how sore they look, how tired and utterly stressed they seem to be.

"Okay."

I frown at him and squint at a small spot on the ceiling. It looks as though it was stabbed with a knife, or was it a sword? It doesn't matter the second I hear him sniffle.

I sit up straight away and and he just stares at me from the floor, tears streaming down his face. My heart feels as though it was just taken from my body.

"I think I'm broken."

He whimpers. I shake my head and open my arms, inviting him in for a hug. He hugs me and buries his face into my shoulder.

"The flashbacks went away for a while, but now they're back. Adora's my sister... I'm he-man... It's so much to take in but..."

I rub circles on his back and he sniffs in a shaky breath.

"I feel nothing. It's like I'm numb."

He pulls his head away and looks at me with an expression so full of fear I don't think I've ever seen it before. I wipe his tears away and ruffle his hair with a smile.

'You're not broken. Not at all.'

I'm not sure if he understands me. It gets difficult when he's upset, I've come to learn. He nods and takes  my hand into both of his.

"When me and Adora go into that ship tomorrow... can you wait for me on the ground?"

He asks. I take him into my arms again and rest my chin on his head.

'Of course I will, Kyle. I'll be waiting for you.'

He sniffles again and wraps his arms around me.

A knock on the door makes both of our heads turn.

"Come in!"

Kyle calls, still wrapped around me. The door creaks open slightly and a small blue creature runs in and leaps on top of of, sending us crashing to the floor. Lonnie comes in soon after and laughs at us.

Her eyes look bloodshot and tired, just like Kyle's do. Am I supposed to be this upset? I haven't had much time to think about anything.

"I just came in to hang for a while. You know, like we used to."

I smile at her as she lies in the floor next to us, outstretching her arms for imp, who crawls to her instantly.

"How you guys holding up?"

She sighs. Me and Kyle share a look of concern but he looks stronger than he was the first time I asked.

"We'll be okay."

Lonnie nods and rolls her eyes as she starts to laugh.

"What's so funny?"

Kyle asks defensively, sitting up and glaring at her. Lonnie laughs even more and I can't help but crack a smile.

"Back in the horde, you two were all over each other, you know. Like seriously."

Kyle raises his eyebrows and flushes crimson.

"That's not true!"

I laugh and sit up, too.

'It kind of is.'

Lonnie laughs and Kyle pouts at the floor for a while before joining in.

"It just got me thinking. All the time we missed these past few years... you guys have finally been free. Free to be together. I'm sorry I missed it."

I smile at her and shake my head.

'We understood why you needed a break.'

There's another knock on the door and the three of us look over in confusion when Adora and Catra peek into the room with smiles.

"Cadet hangout before the big mission?"

Catra asks, and we all laugh. They sit with us and we talk about where we've been, what we used to do, the things we used to joke about.

And for a couple of hours, it's all like it used to be.

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# finale

Kyle's POV

I wake up way too early.

It's barely bright outside, the only hints of morning being the soft birdsong that plays in the distance. If this was the waste... don't think about the waste.

I sit up and look down at Rogelio, who's sleeping soundly with a slight frown on his face.

"We'll get through this."

I whisper, and kiss his forehead softly.

I don't remember walking out of bed but now I stand on the just bright balcony with He-Man's sword in my hands, balancing on the castle railing with the thick blade. It takes everything in my power not to drop the sword over the ledge.

'You're up?'

A familiar pair of strong arms wrap themselves around me from behind and I smile at the sword in my hands with a nod.

"How come I never hear you wake up?"

I ask, but he just hugs me tighter and rests his chin on my soft hair.

'How come you're always awake so early?'

Apparently none of our questions are meant to be answered, because we stand in silence for a few minutes, staring out into the scenery below us.

I turn around and Rogelio smiles down at me, resting the sword on the floor beside his feet.

'I know you can do this.'

He grumbles. I smile back at him and nod.

"Thanks."

I almost flinch in shock at how familiar the setting is.

Me leaning back on the railings with Rogelio's arms holding it either side of me, both of us smiling like idiots...

We've been here before, only it was in the Fright Zone.

"Rogelio..."

A horrible image crosses my mind and I squint my eyes shut to try and get rid of it.

"If something happens to me today, I just want you to know that I love you. I love you so, so much."

My eyes fill up with tears and he pulls me in for a hug again.

'I love you too, and I know nothing bad will happen.'

He growls. I nod and hold on to his t-shirt, almost worried he'll leave if I let go, but all of a sudden he pulls away slightly and wipes my tears away.

'Kyle, will you marry me?'

He growls, and his eyes swell with tears, too. My mouth opens in shock and my cheeks flush red instantly.

"Of course I would Rogelio, but I don't know if I'll make it out alive today."

My argument isn't strong enough because he shakes his head and takes my hand into his. The question bounces around my brain and I feel giddy with both excitement and fear. Maybe it's just the lighting, but Rogelio's skin looks even more vibrant that it usually does and his eyes look even brighter, too. My stomach flips when he holds my hand to his chest.

'Kyle, I love you more than anything else in the world. I know how strong you are, and I know you can do this. And when you do-'

He takes my other hand and smiles at me.

'We can be free, together.'

Almost in an instant the fears I first had waking up have vanished, and I feel like throwing up with how happy I am.

"If I make it out-"

'When you make it out.'

"When I make it out... we can get married someday, somewhere beautiful."

I wrap my arms around Rogelios neck and we both laugh.

"I feel stronger today, Ro. The sword... it's almost like it's ready, waiting for me to fight."

He lifts me up and spins me around in a moment of rare glee before kissing me softly.

'I love you.'

"I love you too."

***

I couldn't have eaten my breakfast faster if I tried. The thick oatmeal stuff that Glimmer slid in front of me and Adora looked lumpy and cold but it was easy to swallow down and quite filling,

too. Adora looks at me now with a look of what I can only guess is concern and pats my hand.

"You okay?"

I nod and smile at the table, remembering my talk with Rogelio.

"I will be, after this is all finished."

Adora nods and smiles, too.

"You seem very happy."

I glance up at her with rosy cheeks and shrug, supposing I could open up to her seeing as she's my... sister. Still weird.

"Me and Rogelio are going to be married someday, when Astra is gone. So I know that once we get rid of her we can finally be free."

Adora smiles and hugs me briefly before ruffling my hair.

"We can do this. Or if we can't, She-Ra and He-Man can."

I laugh and we sit in a comfortable silence before she clears her throat and waves towards the door.

"There's no point wasting any more time, is there? I say we get going as soon as possible."

I nod and the feeling of anxiousness creeps up my spine again.

It's time.

***(sorry for all of the time skips / breaks, but since it's the last proper chapter before the epilogue I want to get to the point)***

The ship looks even bigger now. It's silver sides and top glisten under the sunlight and the small hatches we can just make out on the roof look unfortunately less inviting than they did the first time.

"It's time. Kyle, you get that hatch, I'll get this one. I'm getting the sword and you have to use your sword as the key to fly this thing, got it?"

Adora says into her earpiece, and I stick a thumbs up to her from across the roof. I turn to Rogelio and wrap my arms around him, trying my best to stay strong.

Do this for the waste.
Do this for us.

"I'll try be fast, and I love you, okay?"

He nods at me and squeezes my hand before letting me fall down into the hatch.

'I love you!'

He growls after me, and with that I start to crawl.

The vent is hot and stuffy but I do my best with breathing in and out through my nose and mouth to stop freaking out.

"By the power of greyskull!"

I hiss, and to my delight even with the sword on my back I can transform. I seem to be moving faster as He-Man so I stay in his form, shuffling as swiftly as I can in the direction that Entrapta's plans said to go in.

"Kyle, can you hear me?"

The earpiece crackles. I click on the small device in my ear and clear my throat as quietly as possible.

"Yeah, I can hear you."

"How far along are you?"

"I've taken a right and a left."

"Okay, good. I'm coming to the hatch leading into the hall now."

I continue to crawl even faster when a clicking sound underneath me makes me stop frozen in my tracks. I peek out of the grill in front of me and spot a hint of blue skin.

"She's under where I am, heading for the cockpit. I might need She-Ra's help in there."

When she's gone I slide the grate forwards and climb out of the vent, falling to the floor with a slight thump. I pull the sword from its carrier on my back and hold it in front of me, enjoying how it doesn't weigh me down as He-Man.

"Kyle, I got the sword! I'm heading for the cockpit."

I click my earpiece and mutter a small 'ok'.

The closer I get to the cockpit, the more I focus on how scared I am.

Eventually I reach the door and have no choice but to push it open.

The second I barge into the room Astra turns and smiles at me, three of her crystal henchmen gathered by her sides and staring at me with more malice in their glowing eyes than she ever could. My stomach lurches at the sight of her but I try and look as resilient as possible.

"It's time for you to go, Astra."

I say, pointing the sword in her direction. She laughs, and honestly, nothing could have annoyed me more.

"Oh, Kyle is suddenly a He-Man master! I must concede."

She sings. Her voice echoes around the walls of the room and I cringe.

"I was expecting you sooner, but let me guess; Rogelio."

I flinch at the mention of his name and my grip on the sword tightens.

"Don't talk about him, it's not his fault. This is my fight."

"Prove it."

I run for her but almost straight away one of her guards grabs my wrist and pushes me back. I wriggle free and swing my sword at its abdomen, shards of glass flying out all over the floor from its false wound. Despite the injury, it keeps moving, so I plunge the sword into its glowing centre with a grunt.

She-Ra bursts through the doors the second it dies.

"Adora, you tackle a guard!"

I shout, and head for where I'm supposed to stick my sword, but another guard grabs me and slams me into the floor.

The faint sound of Adora fighting with her guard swims in and out of my earshot, accompanied by a deafening ring.

I can just about make out Astra's blurry figure in my vision beside the guard that's pinning me down.

"Don't you understand?"

She shouts over the noise. I try to get up but I'm distracted when a trail of blood runs down from my nose towards my lip.

"I've put the engine on, Kyle! You and Adora are mine now!"

Her words make me angrier than anything she said before.

"No. You don't win."

I grumble. She laughs at me.

"It's too late. We're already setting flight as we speak! Say goodbye to Etheria, say goodbye to Rogelio."

Rogelio.

Through the hazy view of Astra and the guard holding me down I can see him smiling at me, holding my hand, kissing me, touching me.

I could give up now.

But at what cost? Adora would never see Catra or her friends again. I would never see Rogelio or my friends again. They would be broken. Me and Rogelio... what about our future? Getting married? Having a family? A home?

Being free?

And then all of a sudden I understand why I have to do this.

"No! Get off!"

I shout, and kick the guard from me. It crashes into the wall opposite me and shatters into a couple of glowing chunks. Astra gasps in shock when I rip the cape from my back and use it to tie her arm to the railing on the wall. It's not enough to keep her restrained for long, but it'll do for the key.

The ship starts with a jolt and I tumble over to the buttons and switches, desperately looking for the slot where my sword should fit.

And then there it is. The key to my freedom.

I stick the sword into the slot and try to ignore the sound of Astra struggling to escape her restraint.

"Override initiated. Destination: Latura."

Astra wails in dispair at the ship's voice and I take the sword back as fast as I can, feeling the ship beginning to speed towards it's home.

"Let's go!"

Adora shouts. The floor around her is littered with crystal shards but she looks more alive than ever.

We close the cockpit door and start to run.

Sixty seconds is all we have before the ship is shot into space at full speed, but I'd give anything to have even ten seconds longer.

The corridor is straight, with no obstacles other than the odd crystal guard or waiter, but even then it feels endless. Adora and I stay silent as we run, the sound of Astra roaring in anger and our fast paced footsteps our only music.

Adora throws her sword at the panel that opens the door and it starts to lower. The air becomes extremely cold and we realise at the same time that we're hovering a little over the ground, maybe even a couple of metres up into the sky.

Adora rips her sword from the panel and we stare out of the back of the ship with wide eyes.

We're up high. Not high enough to injure ourselves from falling, but high enough to need a leap towards the ground. I'm about to retreat in fear when I see Rogelio waving at me. Beside him are all of the princess alliance,  all of our friends, even Entrapta and Hordak are waiting with them as me and Adora fly higher and higher into the sky.

I look over at her and she reaches her hand out for me to take. I hold it and we nod to each other before jumping out of the ship.

We fall in slow motion.

I can hear the ship doors closing behind us, but I can also hear our friends cheering and clapping. Most importantly I can see Rogelio waiting to catch me, and Catra waiting for Adora to reach her, so I turn back into Kyle and nearly flatten Rogelio into the ground with how hard I slam into him. We both fall over in a heap and I start to cry.

Happy tears, I think. Or exhausted ones, stressed ones, sad ones. It doesn't matter, because as my friends cheer for us and share hugs, and as the ship zips into the air and completely out of sight, my eyes focus only on Rogelio.

My legs are wrapped around his waist and my arms around his neck as he holds me.

"We did it. She's gone."

I whisper, crying and laughing at the same time. Rogelio nods and I notice a tear slip down his face. His voice sends waves of happiness and joy around my body as he speaks, nothing around us mattering anymore.

'Good riddance.'

And immediately, I understand.

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# epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rogelio's POV

"She's so cute, isn't she?"

Kyle asks, wrapping his arm around mine and nuzzling his face into me. I nod and rest my head on his with a smile. Our small daughter Clara weaves in and out of everyone's legs with a huge smile on her face. Her pale skin and blonde hair are all Kyle's, but her tail and scaly arms and hands resemble my own. Her cousin Finn runs after her and I laugh when Lonnie chases them around everyone. I remember how elated we were when magic did it’s thing and brought Clara to us.

'Yeah.'

It’s hard to believe it’s our wedding day.

Kyle sits up and I look down to him, our eyes meeting the way they always do. He smiles at me and glances to Clara. I notice how he has lost his teen features and grown up quite a bit, his jawline much more prominent and hints of stubble growing around his chin the most noticeable.

"I understand it now. I understand."

He says. I frown at him and shake my head, not following what he's trying to say.

'Understand what?'

He smiles again and reaches up to rest a hand on my face, curling his fingers slightly and leaning forwards, much closer than he was before.

"Everything."

I smile at him and nod, when Clara comes over to us with a smile on her face.

"Dad, Papa! Auntie Adora said it's time for your dance!"

Kyle looks up at me and laughs.

"Well then 'papa', we better go."

I nod and Clara squeals in excitement when we take to the floor. At first it was awkward with everyone staring at us, seeing as this wasn't usually something everyone watched, but after a few seconds it becomes enjoyable, and our friends' eyes that are full of admiration are more encouraging.

When more people start to join in Clara runs to us and I pick her up, spinning her around as she giggles. Kyle ruffles her hair and the three of us stand together, all of our friends enjoying themselves around us.

I never thought we'd get here. Every since Shadow Weaver told us off all those years ago, telling us we would be punished severely if she caught us together again, I thought that was it. I thought we would either be forced apart, or punished so cruelly we wouldn't be able to look at each other the same way again. But then it all changed.

The day that Scorpia and Glimmer broke into the Fright Zone was the day we escaped. We found a new home, a new life. Lonnie wanted some time away, but we didn't mind.

Then a couple of years later, the universe sent another cruel sign. Astra arrived. She destroyed our home and everything we worked for.

But she introduced us to He-Man, and without her landing we would have never found out about Kyle's relation to Adora.

Regardless of all of the mess we've been through, and all of the crazy twists and turns we've had come our way, Kyle and I always find each other. We keep each other safe.

We understand each other.

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Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for reading. I understand this so kinda cringe, but I did write it in lockdown and I feel i’ve gotten better since then!! anyways, i hope there’s something in here that made it worth reading. Till we meet again!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!